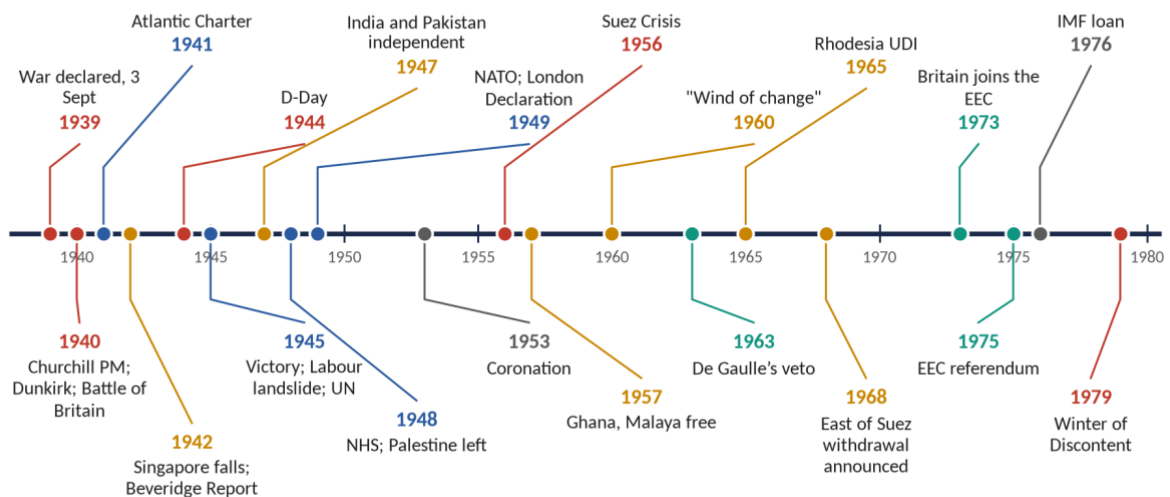


The Second World War, Attlee, the Cold War and the End of Empire (1939–1979)

Britain's finest hour and its long retreat — the Second World War, Churchill, the war conferences and the United Nations, the Attlee welfare state, the Cold War and NATO, the Commonwealth, decolonisation, India, Palestine and Suez, home affairs and the EEC to 1979, with the story carried on to 2026

BRITAIN 1939–1979

red = war and crisis · blue = war, welfare and alliances · gold = empire · teal = Europe



Syllabus heads XII and XIII. The largest topic of all: 14 past items in 2015–2026 — the Commonwealth 3, decolonisation and India 3, Suez and the Middle East 2, Churchill 2, the Second World War 2, Attlee, and

Britain and the USA — and **10 MCQs**. Told from zero, then **eleven chapters** covering both heads in full, with **120 one-liners** and a stand-alone **revision sheet**.

Topic 8 of 10 · read with the companion document T8QA

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How to Use This Document

What this Topic covers

Topic 8 covers the forty years from **1939** to **1979**. It takes in syllabus **Head XII** (Britain and the **Second World War**: causes and events; **Churchill** and the war conferences; the creation of the **United Nations**; the effects of the war; the reforms of the **Labour government**) and **Head XIII** (Britain and the **Cold War**: the creation of the **Commonwealth**; **NATO**; **decolonisation**; internal policies and the **EEC**; foreign policy).

WHAT THE EXAMINER HAS ASKED · Why this topic matters

14 items in 2015–2026 and 10 MCQs — more than any other topic. The favourites: the **Commonwealth** (2015, 2017, 2024 sn), **decolonisation** (2019 with India, 2024, 2026), the **Middle East and Suez** (2020, 2022 sn), **Churchill** (2018 sn, 2022), the **Second World War** (2016 sn, 2023), **Attlee** (2019) and **Britain's relationship with the USA** (2018). Every one is answered in T8QA; this Knowledge Base also covers the parts not yet asked — the **war conferences and the UN**, **NATO**, **home policy 1951–79** and the **EEC**.

THE STORY IN SIMPLE WORDS · Where this topic fits in the story

Topic 7 ended with Britain declaring war on Germany on **3 September 1939**. Topic 8 tells how Britain survived and won that war under **Churchill**, built a **welfare state** under **Attlee**, joined the **USA** in the **Cold War**, gave up almost all its **empire**, and turned towards **Europe**. Topic 9 continues from **Margaret Thatcher** (1979).

Part Zero — The ABC Before the Story

0.1 Britain in 1939 — the simple picture

- **A great power, but a tired one:** the largest empire in history (about a quarter of the world's people), a strong navy, but an economy weakened by the First World War and the Depression.
- **Government:** the **National Government** under **Neville Chamberlain**, mainly Conservative.
- **The enemy:** **Nazi Germany** under **Adolf Hitler**, allied with **Fascist Italy** (Mussolini) and, from 1940, **Japan** — together, the **Axis**.
- **The allies:** at first only **France**, the **Dominions** (Canada, Australia, New Zealand, South Africa) and the **colonies**, above all **India**.

0.2 Britain in 1979 — the other end

- **The empire had gone:** only a few small territories (Hong Kong, Gibraltar, the Falklands) remained.
- **A welfare state:** the NHS, pensions, benefits, council housing.
- **A member of the European Economic Community** (since **1973**).
- **A junior partner of the USA** in **NATO** and the Cold War; a **nuclear** power.
- **An economy in trouble:** inflation, strikes, the IMF loan (1976), the "**Winter of Discontent**" (1978–79).

0.3 The words you need

Word	What it means, simply
Axis / Allies	Germany, Italy and Japan / Britain, the Commonwealth, the USSR, the USA and others.
Blitzkrieg	"Lightning war": fast attacks with tanks and aircraft.
The Blitz	The German bombing of British cities, 1940–41.
Grand Alliance	Britain, the USSR and the USA together against Hitler (from 1941).
United Nations (UN)	The world organisation founded in 1945 to keep peace — the League's successor.
Welfare state	A state that protects all citizens against poverty, sickness and unemployment "from the cradle to the grave".
Nationalisation	The state taking over an industry (coal, railways) from private owners.
Cold War	The rivalry (1947–1991) between the USA with its allies and the USSR with its allies — without direct war between them.
Iron Curtain	The line dividing communist Eastern Europe from the West (Churchill, 1946).
NATO	The North Atlantic Treaty Organisation (1949): a defence alliance of the USA, Canada, Britain and Western Europe.

Word	What it means, simply
Special relationship	The close alliance between Britain and the USA (Churchill's phrase, 1946).
Decolonisation	The process by which colonies became independent states.
Dominion	A self-governing former colony, such as Canada or Australia.
Commonwealth	The voluntary association of independent states, mostly former British territories.
Mandate	A territory (e.g. Palestine) run by Britain on behalf of the League of Nations.
Partition	Dividing a country into separate states (India and Pakistan, 1947).
EEC	The European Economic Community (1957) — the "Common Market", ancestor of the European Union.
Consensus	The broad agreement of the main parties (1945–79) on the welfare state, full employment and a mixed economy.

KEY IDEA · The one idea to hold on to

Britain **won** the Second World War but was **exhausted** by it. For the next forty years it built a **welfare state** at home while it lost an **empire** abroad, and searched for a new role — as America's closest ally, as head of the **Commonwealth**, and finally as a member of **Europe**. As the US statesman Dean Acheson said in **1962**: "**Great Britain has lost an empire and has not yet found a role.**"

Part One — The Story

THE STORY IN SIMPLE WORDS · The story in simple words

Read this Part first, straight through. Every event is explained in detail in the chapters.

1.1 Britain alone (1939–1941)

After Germany invaded Poland, Britain declared war on **3 September 1939**. Nothing much happened in the West for months — the "**Phoney War**". Then in **April–May 1940** Hitler overran Norway, Denmark, the Netherlands, Belgium and France. **Winston Churchill** became Prime Minister on **10 May 1940**. The British army was trapped at **Dunkirk** and rescued by a fleet of warships and little boats (**Operation Dynamo**). France surrendered in **June**. Britain stood **alone**. In the **Battle of Britain** (summer 1940) the RAF defeated the German air force and Hitler's invasion was called off. German bombers then attacked British cities night after night — **the Blitz** (1940–41).

1.2 The Grand Alliance (1941–1945)

In **June 1941** Hitler invaded the **Soviet Union**; in **December 1941** Japan attacked the Americans at **Pearl Harbor**, and the **USA** entered the war. Britain now had powerful allies. Japan conquered **Malaya** and **Singapore** (**February 1942**) — a humiliating British defeat. But in late 1942 the tide turned: the British won at **El Alamein** in Egypt, the Soviets at **Stalingrad**, the Americans at **Midway**. On **6 June 1944** — **D-Day** — Allied armies landed in **Normandy**. Germany surrendered on **8 May 1945** (**VE Day**). After atomic bombs fell on **Hiroshima** and **Nagasaki**, Japan surrendered in **August 1945**.

1.3 The people's peace (1945–1951)

In **July 1945** the voters threw out Churchill and elected **Labour** under **Clement Attlee** with a huge majority. Following the **Beveridge Report** (1942), Labour built the **welfare state** — above all the **National Health Service** (**1948**) — and took coal, railways and other industries into public ownership. But Britain was nearly bankrupt; it borrowed from America and lived through years of **austerity** and **rationing**.

1.4 The Cold War (1946–1979)

The wartime alliance with the Soviet Union broke down. In **1946** Churchill warned that an "**Iron Curtain**" had fallen across Europe. Britain helped create **NATO** (**1949**), built its own **atomic bomb** (**1952**), fought in **Korea** (1950–53), and became America's closest ally — the "**special relationship**".

1.5 The end of empire (1947–1980)

Britain began to give up its empire. **India and Pakistan** became independent in **August 1947**, **Burma** and **Ceylon** in **1948**; Britain left **Palestine** in **1948**. In **1956** Britain and France invaded Egypt to regain the **Suez Canal**, but the USA forced them to withdraw — a turning point. Prime Minister **Harold Macmillan** spoke of a "**wind of change**" in Africa (**1960**); within a few years almost all the African colonies were free. The former colonies joined a new, free **Commonwealth**.

1.6 Home and Europe (1951–1979)

The Conservatives governed from **1951 to 1964**: rationing ended, and Macmillan said people had "**never had it so good**". The 1960s brought "**Swinging London**". Britain was twice refused entry to the **EEC** by France's **de Gaulle** (1963, 1967) and finally joined in **1973**. The 1970s were troubled: strikes, a **three-day week** (1974), high inflation, an emergency loan from the **IMF** (1976) and the strikes of the "**Winter of Discontent**" (1978–79), which brought **Margaret Thatcher** to power in **May 1979**.

VERDICT · The story in one sentence

Between 1939 and 1979 Britain fought and won a world war under Churchill, built a welfare state under Attlee, became America's chief ally in the Cold War, peacefully (mostly) gave up the largest empire in history in favour of a free Commonwealth, and at last joined Europe — while struggling with economic decline.

Part Two — The Cast and the Time-line

2.1 The cast

Person	Dates / office	Who they were — in one line
Winston Churchill	PM 1940–45, 1951–55	War leader; statesman; Nobel Prize for Literature (1953).
Clement Attlee	PM 1945–51	Labour leader who built the welfare state and freed India.
Ernest Bevin	Foreign Sec. 1945–51	Labour's Foreign Secretary; a founder of NATO.
Aneurin Bevan	Health Minister 1945–51	Created the NHS.
Sir Stafford Cripps	Chancellor 1947–50	"Austerity"; the Cripps Mission to India (1942).
William Beveridge	1879–1963	His Report (1942) planned the welfare state.
Franklin D. Roosevelt	US President 1933–45	Churchill's partner; Lend-Lease; Atlantic Charter.
Joseph Stalin	Soviet leader 1924–53	Wartime ally; Cold War enemy.
Harry Truman	US President 1945–53	Truman Doctrine; Marshall Plan; NATO.
Anthony Eden	PM 1955–57	Resigned after Suez.
Harold Macmillan	PM 1957–63	"Never had it so good"; "wind of change"; first EEC application.
Iain Macleod	Colonial Sec. 1959–61	Sped up African independence.
Harold Wilson	PM 1964–70, 1974–76	Devaluation; East of Suez withdrawal; the 1975 referendum.
Edward Heath	PM 1970–74	Took Britain into the EEC (1973).
James Callaghan	PM 1976–79	IMF loan; Winter of Discontent.
Mahatma Gandhi	1869–1948	Leader of Indian non-violent nationalism.
Jawaharlal Nehru	1889–1964	Congress leader; India's first PM.
Muhammad Ali Jinnah	1876–1948	Leader of the Muslim League; founder of Pakistan.
Lord Mountbatten	Viceroy 1947	The last Viceroy of India.
Gamal Abdel Nasser	Egypt 1954–70	Nationalised the Suez Canal (1956).
Charles de Gaulle	France 1958–69	Vetoed Britain's EEC entry twice.
Elizabeth II	Queen 1952–2022	Crowned 2 June 1953 ; Head of the Commonwealth for 70 years.

2.2 The time-line

BRITAIN 1939–1979

red = war and crisis · blue = war, welfare and alliances · gold = empire · teal = Europe

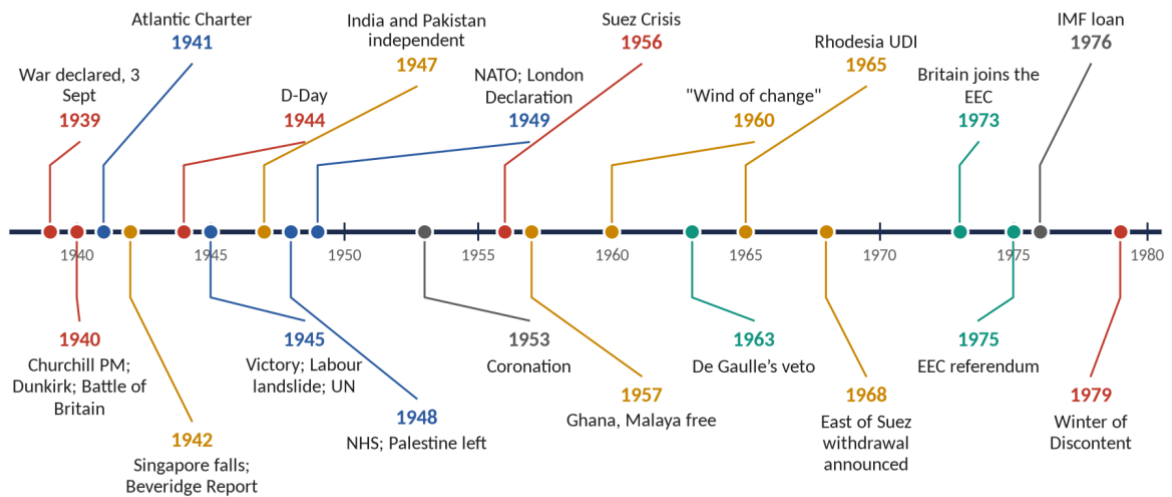


Figure 1 · Britain 1939–1979.

Part Three — The Chapters

Chapter 1 · The Second World War, 1939–1945

1.1 The causes

Cause	Explanation
The Treaty of Versailles (1919)	Germany resented the war guilt clause, reparations, lost lands and disarmament; Hitler promised to destroy the treaty.
The Great Depression (1929–33)	Mass unemployment in Germany helped the Nazis to power (January 1933); in Japan it strengthened the militarists.
Hitler's aims	To overturn Versailles, unite all Germans, and win Lebensraum ("living space") in the East — ideas set out in <i>Mein Kampf</i> (1925).
The failure of the League	Manchuria (1931) and Abyssinia (1935) showed aggression paid (Topic 7).
Appeasement	Britain and France gave way over the Rhineland (1936), Austria (1938) and the Sudetenland (Munich , 1938), encouraging Hitler.
The Nazi–Soviet Pact (23 August 1939)	Hitler and Stalin agreed not to fight each other and secretly to divide Poland — Hitler could attack Poland without fearing a two-front war.
The invasion of Poland (1 September 1939)	Britain and France had guaranteed Poland (March 1939); they declared war on 3 September .

KEY IDEA · The historians

A. J. P. Taylor (1961) saw Hitler as an opportunist and blamed the Western powers' mistakes; most historians (e.g. **Alan Bullock**, **Richard Overy**) see Hitler's long-term aims of expansion and racial war as the central cause.

1.2 The course of the war — Britain's story

BRITAIN'S WAR IN EUROPE AND NORTH AFRICA, 1939–1945

Key places in the British story of the Second World War

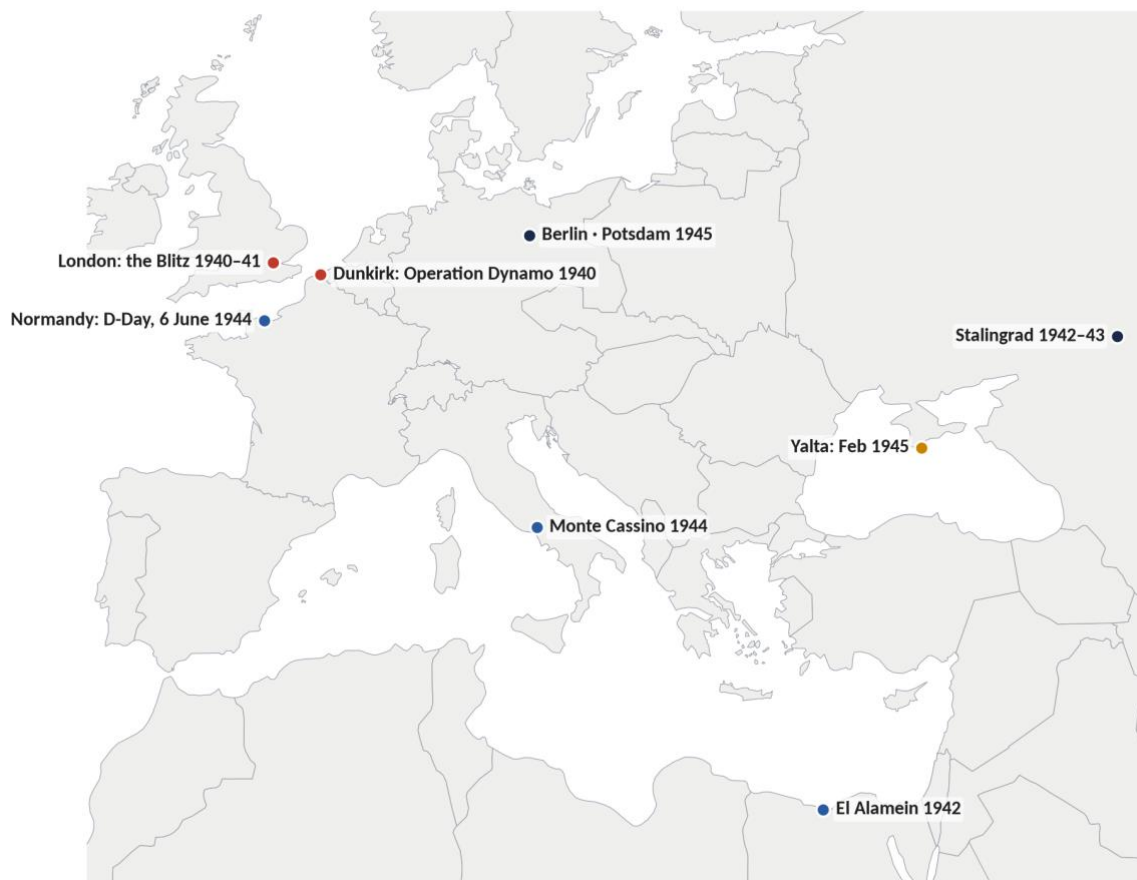


Figure 2 · Britain's war in Europe and North Africa.

(i) 1939–1940: the Phoney War and the fall of the West

- **September 1939 – April 1940:** the "**Phoney War**" — little fighting in the West; Poland was conquered in weeks.
- **April 1940:** Germany invaded **Denmark** and **Norway**; the British campaign in Norway failed.
- **7–8 May 1940:** the **Norway debate** in the Commons; Leo Amery quoted Cromwell to Chamberlain: "**In the name of God, go!**"
- **10 May 1940:** Germany attacked the Netherlands, Belgium and France; **Churchill became Prime Minister** of a coalition government (with Labour).
- **13 May:** Churchill: "I have nothing to offer but **blood, toil, tears and sweat.**"
- **26 May – 4 June 1940:** **Operation Dynamo** — the evacuation from **Dunkirk** of about **338,000** British and French soldiers, using warships and hundreds of "**little ships**". Churchill: "**We shall fight on the beaches ... we shall never surrender**" (4 June).
- **22 June 1940:** **France surrendered.** Churchill: "Let us ... so bear ourselves that ... men will still say, **This was their finest hour**" (18 June).

(ii) 1940–1941: Britain alone

- **The Battle of Britain (July–October 1940)**: the German air force (**Luftwaffe**) tried to destroy the **RAF** to prepare an invasion (**Operation Sea Lion**). The RAF's **Spitfires** and **Hurricanes**, guided by **radar**, won. Churchill: "**Never in the field of human conflict was so much owed by so many to so few**" (20 August). **15 September** is "Battle of Britain Day". Hitler postponed the invasion.
- **The Blitz (September 1940 – May 1941)**: night bombing of **London**, **Coventry** (November 1940), **Liverpool**, **Birmingham**, **Glasgow** and other cities; about **43,000** civilians killed.
- **The Battle of the Atlantic** (1939–45): German **U-boats** attacked the ships bringing food and arms; convoys, radar, air cover and the breaking of the **Enigma** code at **Bletchley Park** won it by **1943**.
- **Lend-Lease (March 1941)**: the USA supplied Britain with arms, to be paid for later.
- **North Africa and the Mediterranean**: victories over Italy (1940–41), then defeats by **Rommel's Afrika Korps**; Greece and Crete lost (1941).

(iii) 1941–1942: a world war

- **22 June 1941: Operation Barbarossa** — Germany invaded the **USSR**. Churchill at once offered help: "If Hitler invaded Hell I would make at least a favourable reference to the devil in the House of Commons."
- **August 1941**: the **Atlantic Charter** (Chapter 3).
- **7 December 1941**: Japan attacked **Pearl Harbor**; the **USA** entered the war. Churchill: "So we had won after all!"
- **15 February 1942: Singapore** surrendered to Japan — about **80,000** British, Indian and Australian troops captured; Churchill called it "**the worst disaster and largest capitulation in British history**". Burma was lost; India was threatened.

(iv) 1942–1945: the tide turns

- **El Alamein (23 October – 4 November 1942)**: **General Montgomery's** Eighth Army defeated **Rommel**. Churchill: "**Before Alamein we never had a victory. After Alamein we never had a defeat.**" The Axis were cleared from North Africa (**May 1943**).
- **Stalingrad** (1942–43): the great Soviet victory.
- **Italy** (1943–45): the invasion of **Sicily** (July 1943) and Italy; **Mussolini** fell; slow fighting (Monte Cassino, 1944).
- **The bombing of Germany: RAF Bomber Command** under **Arthur Harris** — **Hamburg** (1943), **Dresden (February 1945)** — about 55,000 aircrew killed; still debated.
- **D-Day (6 June 1944): Operation Overlord** — British, American and Canadian forces landed on five **Normandy** beaches (about 156,000 men on the first day); Paris freed (August 1944).
- **Burma: General Slim's "Forgotten Army"** defeated the Japanese at **Imphal and Kohima** (1944) and retook Burma (1945).
- **Victory in Europe**: Hitler killed himself on **30 April 1945**; Germany surrendered — **VE Day, 8 May 1945**.

- **Victory over Japan:** atomic bombs on **Hiroshima (6 August)** and **Nagasaki (9 August)**; Japan surrendered (**15 August, VJ Day**; signed **2 September 1945**).

1.3 The home front

- **Evacuation:** about **1.5 million** children, mothers and others moved from cities to the countryside in the first days (**September 1939**) — middle-class Britain discovered the poverty of city children.
- **Rationing:** from **January 1940** (bacon, butter, sugar), extended to meat, tea, clothes; "**Dig for Victory**".
- **Total mobilisation:** **Ernest Bevin**, Minister of Labour, directed workers; **conscription of women (December 1941)** — the first country to do so; by 1943 most single women aged 19–40 were in the forces, industry or civil defence.
- **Civil defence:** the ARP (air raid wardens), the **Home Guard**, the Auxiliary Fire Service.
- **Planning for peace:** the **Beveridge Report (December 1942)**; the **Butler Education Act (1944)**; the white paper on full employment (1944).
- "**The people's war**": shared danger and fair shares created a sense of national unity and a demand for a better Britain after the war.

1.4 The cost

- **British deaths:** about **384,000** servicemen and about **67,000** civilians — about **450,000** in all (fewer than in 1914–18).
- **World deaths:** about **70–85 million**, including **6 million Jews** murdered in the Holocaust.
- **Britain's economy:** see Chapter 4.

WHAT THE EXAMINER HAS ASKED · Where Chapter 1 has been asked

2023 Q6 (causes, major developments and aftermath) · **2016 Q8(a)** (short note: the Second World War). MCQs **2025:** the Dunkirk evacuation was **Operation Dynamo**; the German bombing campaign was **the Blitz**.

Chapter 2 · Winston Churchill (1874–1965)

WINSTON CHURCHILL (1874–1965): THREE LIVES IN ONE

Soldier, politician and writer

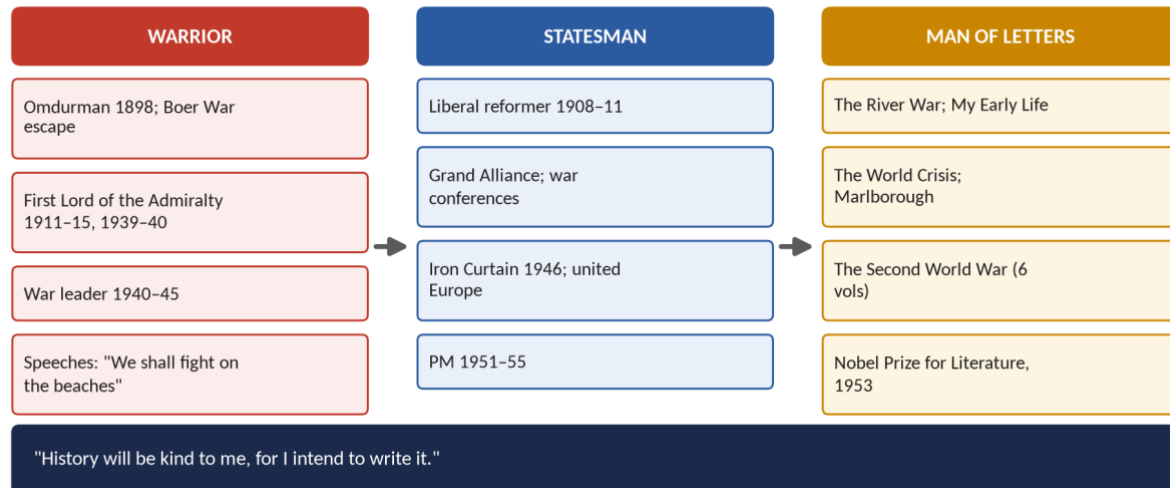


Figure 3 · Churchill: soldier, statesman, writer.

2.1 His life at a glance

Years	Event
1874	Born at Blenheim Palace , son of Lord Randolph Churchill and the American Jennie Jerome.
1893–95	Harrow; Sandhurst military college; the 4th Hussars.
1895–1900	Soldier and war correspondent: Cuba (1895), the North-West Frontier of India (1897), the Sudan — he rode in the cavalry charge at Omdurman (1898) — and the Boer War , where he was captured and escaped (1899) , becoming a national hero.
1900	Conservative MP for Oldham.
1904	Crossed the floor to the Liberals over free trade.
1908–10	President of the Board of Trade : labour exchanges , trade boards.
1910–11	Home Secretary : Tonypandy; the siege of Sidney Street; prison reform.
1911–15	First Lord of the Admiralty : prepared the navy for war; the failed Gallipoli campaign (1915) cost him his post.
1916	Served as a battalion commander on the Western Front .
1917–22	Minister of Munitions (1917); War and Air (1919–21); Colonial Secretary (1921–22) — the Irish Treaty, the Middle East settlement.
1924	Rejoined the Conservatives : "Anyone can rat, but it takes a certain ingenuity to re-rat."
1924–29	Chancellor of the Exchequer : returned to the gold standard (1925) — later he called it the biggest mistake of his life; the <i>British Gazette</i> in the General Strike.
1929–39	The " wilderness years ": out of office; opposed Indian self-government; supported Edward VIII (1936); warned constantly against Hitler and demanded rearmament ; condemned Munich .

Years	Event
1939–40	First Lord of the Admiralty again (" Winston is back ").
1940–45	Prime Minister of the wartime coalition.
1945	Defeated in the general election.
1946	The " Iron Curtain " speech at Fulton , Missouri (5 March); the Zurich speech calling for a "United States of Europe" (September).
1951–55	Prime Minister again.
1953	Knighted (Garter); Nobel Prize for Literature .
1965	Died on 24 January ; state funeral .

2.2 Churchill the warrior

(i) The young soldier

A brave, adventurous cavalry officer who deliberately sought danger and fame: Cuba, the North-West Frontier, **Omdurman** (1898) and the Boer War (capture and escape, 1899). In **1916** he commanded the 6th Royal Scots Fusiliers in the trenches.

(ii) Director of war (1911–15)

As **First Lord of the Admiralty** he modernised the navy (oil-fired ships, the naval air service, early work on the **tank**) and had the fleet ready in 1914. But the **Dardanelles/Gallipoli** campaign (**1915**) — his plan to knock Turkey out of the war — ended in disaster, and he was dismissed.

(iii) The war leader (1940–45)

- 1. Defiance:** in **May 1940**, when some ministers (Halifax) wanted to explore peace terms through Mussolini, Churchill insisted on fighting on.
- 2. Inspiration:** his speeches and broadcasts — "blood, toil, tears and sweat", "we shall fight on the beaches", "their finest hour", "the few" — gave the nation courage. As Ed Murrow said, "he mobilised the English language and sent it into battle".
- 3. Energy and control:** he was also **Minister of Defence**, drove the service chiefs hard, visited bombed cities and the front, and read Enigma intelligence ("Action this day").
- 4. Strategy:** he defended the **Middle East** and **Mediterranean** (Alamein, North Africa, Italy — "the soft underbelly of Europe"), supported the bombing of Germany, and delayed the cross-Channel invasion until **1944**, when it could succeed.
- 5. Alliance-building:** his friendship with **Roosevelt** brought American aid (Lend-Lease) and, after Pearl Harbor, a joint strategy ("Germany first"); he kept the alliance with **Stalin** together.

(iv) Criticisms

Gallipoli (1915); the Norway campaign (1940); Greece (1941); the loss of **Singapore** (1942); interference with his generals; the bombing of **Dresden**; his government's handling of the **Bengal famine (1943)**, in which about 3 million died.

2.3 Churchill the statesman

(i) Before 1940

- **Liberal reformer** (1908–11): labour exchanges, trade boards, prison reform — one of the builders of the early welfare state.
- **Colonial Secretary**: the **Irish Treaty** (1921); the Cairo Conference (1921) — the kingdoms of Iraq and Transjordan.
- **Chancellor**: widows' pensions (1925); but the **gold standard** (1925) was a mistake.
- **Prophet**: his warnings against **Hitler** in the 1930s were proved right.
- **But**: opposition to Indian self-government (the **India Act 1935**) and support for Edward VIII damaged his judgement's reputation.

(ii) War statesman

- **The war conferences** (Chapter 3): Placentia Bay (1941), Washington (1941–42), **Casablanca** (1943), **Tehran** (1943), **Moscow** (the "**percentages agreement**" with Stalin, 1944), **Yalta** (1945), **Potsdam** (1945).
- **Founding the United Nations**; the **Atlantic Charter**.
- **The coalition** with Labour at home — Attlee as Deputy PM.

(iii) Post-war statesman

- **The "Iron Curtain" speech (Fulton, 5 March 1946)**: "From Stettin in the Baltic to Trieste in the Adriatic, an **iron curtain** has descended across the Continent"; he called for a "**special relationship**" between Britain and the USA.
- **Europe**: the **Zurich speech** (1946) called for "a kind of **United States of Europe**" (though with Britain outside, linked to it).
- **The three circles**: Britain at the meeting point of the **Commonwealth**, the **English-speaking world** (the USA) and **Europe**.
- **Prime Minister 1951–55**: accepted the welfare state; built **300,000** houses a year (Macmillan); ended rationing (1954); the **coronation** (1953); decided to build the **hydrogen bomb**; sought a summit with the Soviets after Stalin's death. He suffered a stroke (1953) and retired in **April 1955**.

2.4 Churchill the man of letters

- **Journalist and war correspondent**: *The Story of the Malakand Field Force* (1898), *The River War* (1899, the Sudan campaign), *London to Ladysmith* (1900).
- **Novelist**: *Savrola* (1900).

- **Biographer:** *Lord Randolph Churchill* (1906); ***Marlborough: His Life and Times*** (4 volumes, 1933–38) — on his great ancestor.
- **Memoir:** ***My Early Life*** (1930).
- **Historian of his own times:** ***The World Crisis*** (1923–31, on the First World War) — Balfour joked that "Winston has written an enormous book about himself and called it *The World Crisis*"; ***The Second World War*** (6 volumes, 1948–53).
- **National historian:** ***A History of the English-Speaking Peoples*** (4 volumes, 1956–58).
- **Orator:** his speeches are part of English literature.
- **The Nobel Prize for Literature (1953):** "for his mastery of historical and biographical description as well as for brilliant oratory in defending exalted human values".
- **Painter:** hundreds of paintings (*Painting as a Pastime*, 1948).
- **His famous joke:** "History will be kind to me, for I intend to write it."

2.5 Assessment

- In a 2002 BBC poll he was voted the **Greatest Briton**.
- **Admirers** (Martin Gilbert, Roy Jenkins, Andrew Roberts): the man who saved Britain and Western freedom in 1940.
- **Critics** (Clive Ponting, John Charmley): his mistakes, his imperialism and racial attitudes (India, Bengal), and the cost of total victory — the loss of British independence to the USA and of the empire.

WHAT THE EXAMINER HAS ASKED · Where Chapter 2 has been asked

2022 Q7 (statesman, warrior and man of letters) · **2018 Q8(a)** (short note). MCQ **2025:** the "Iron Curtain" speech was made famous by **Churchill** himself (none of the options).

Chapter 3 · The War Conferences and the United Nations

3.1 The great conferences

Conference	Date	Main decisions
Placentia Bay (Newfoundland)	Aug 1941	Churchill and Roosevelt issued the Atlantic Charter .
Arcadia (Washington)	Dec 1941 – Jan 1942	" Germany first "; the Declaration by United Nations (1 January 1942).
Casablanca	Jan 1943	Unconditional surrender of the Axis; invasion of Sicily.
Cairo	Nov 1943	Churchill, Roosevelt, Chiang Kai-shek on Japan.
Tehran	Nov–Dec 1943	First meeting of the Big Three ; D-Day fixed for 1944; Poland's borders discussed.
Bretton Woods (USA)	July 1944	The IMF and World Bank ; fixed exchange rates.
Dumbarton Oaks (Washington)	Aug–Oct 1944	Draft plan for the United Nations .
Moscow	Oct 1944	Churchill and Stalin's secret " percentages agreement " on the Balkans (e.g. Greece 90% British, Romania 90% Soviet).
Yalta (Crimea)	Feb 1945	Germany to be divided into zones; free elections in liberated Europe (the "Declaration on Liberated Europe"); Poland's borders moved west; the USSR to join the war on Japan; the UN's Security Council veto .
San Francisco	Apr–June 1945	The UN Charter signed (26 June 1945) by 50 nations.
Potsdam (near Berlin)	July–Aug 1945	Germany disarmed, de-Nazified, divided; reparations; war-crimes trials. Attlee replaced Churchill halfway through after Labour's victory.

3.2 The Atlantic Charter (14 August 1941)

Eight principles for the post-war world, agreed by Churchill and Roosevelt before the USA even entered the war:

1. No territorial gains for themselves.
2. No territorial changes against the wishes of the peoples concerned.
3. **The right of all peoples to choose their own form of government** (self-determination).
4. Equal access to trade and raw materials.
5. Economic cooperation and better labour standards.
6. Freedom from fear and want.
7. Freedom of the seas.

8. Abandonment of force; disarmament; a permanent system of security.

KEY IDEA · The Charter and the Empire

Churchill insisted that point 3 applied only to Europe, not to the British Empire. But nationalists in **India, Burma and Africa** — and the Americans — took it to apply everywhere. It became an argument for **decolonisation**.

3.3 The creation of the United Nations

- **The name** "United Nations" was first used in the **Declaration by United Nations (1 January 1942)** — 26 states pledged to fight the Axis together.
- **Dumbarton Oaks** (1944) drafted the structure; **Yalta** (1945) agreed the **veto** for the great powers.
- **San Francisco** (April–June 1945): the **Charter** was signed on **26 June 1945**; the UN came into existence on **24 October 1945** (UN Day).
- **Headquarters**: New York.

Structure

Organ	Role
General Assembly	All members, one vote each; discusses any issue; recommendations.
Security Council	Responsible for peace and security; five permanent members with a veto — the USA , the USSR (now Russia), Britain , France and China — plus elected members; can order sanctions and military action.
Secretariat	Led by the Secretary-General (first: Trygve Lie).
International Court of Justice	At The Hague.
Economic and Social Council	Development, health, human rights.
Trusteeship Council	Supervised former mandates on the way to independence.
Specialised agencies	UNESCO, WHO, FAO, UNICEF, the ILO, the IMF and World Bank.

How it differed from the League

The UN included the **USA** and the **USSR** from the start; the **Security Council** could order **binding** action and use members' forces; the **veto** kept the great powers inside. Britain, as a permanent member, gained a lasting place among the great powers.

Chapter 4 · The Effects of the Second World War on Britain

4.1 Economic effects

1. **Debt:** Britain spent about a quarter of its national wealth; the national debt roughly **trebled** to about **£21 billion**; it owed about **£3.5 billion** to other countries (the "**sterling balances**", much of it to India and Egypt).
2. **Overseas investments:** about **£1 billion** sold — the income that had paid for imports was gone.
3. **Exports** had fallen to about **a third** of their pre-war level.
4. **Lend-Lease ended** suddenly in **August 1945**. **Keynes** warned of a "**financial Dunkirk**". Britain negotiated a **US loan** of **\$3.75 billion** (plus \$1.25 billion from Canada) in **December 1945** — finally repaid in **2006**.
5. **Physical damage:** about **4 million** homes damaged or destroyed; shipping and industry worn out.
6. **But:** full employment, a larger state, new industries (aircraft, electronics) and a planned economy.

4.2 Social effects

- **Social solidarity:** evacuation, rationing and the Blitz created a sense of "**fair shares**" and "**we're all in it together**".
- **Beveridge:** the demand that there should be no return to the 1930s; the **welfare state**.
- **Women:** huge wartime roles, though most left paid work after 1945.
- **Health:** rationing improved the diet of the poor; infant mortality fell.

4.3 Political effects

- **Labour's landslide (July 1945):** **393** seats to the Conservatives' **197** — the voters chose the party most identified with Beveridge and reform.
- **The post-war consensus:** both parties accepted the welfare state, full employment and a mixed economy until the 1970s ("**Butskellism**" — from Butler and Gaitskell).

4.4 International and imperial effects

- **Two superpowers:** the **USA** and the **USSR** now dominated the world; Britain was the third power, but far behind.
- **Dependence on the USA:** money, and later nuclear weapons.

- **The Empire weakened:** the fall of **Singapore** destroyed British prestige in Asia; **India** had been promised independence; nationalists everywhere were stronger; the **Atlantic Charter** and **UN Charter** proclaimed self-determination.
- **Europe divided:** the start of the Cold War.

Chapter 5 · The Attlee Government, 1945–1951

ATTLEE'S ANSWER TO BEVERIDGE'S "FIVE GIANTS"

The welfare state built by the Labour government of 1945–51

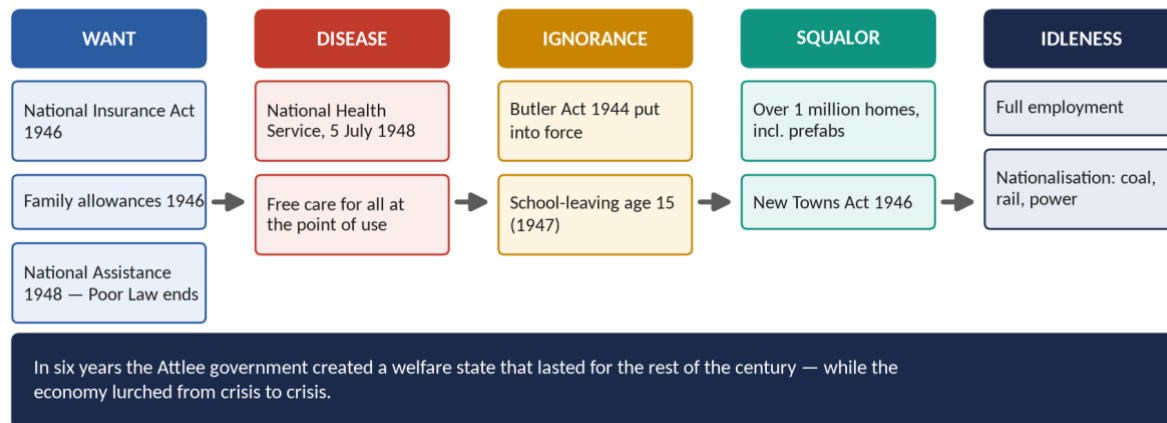


Figure 4 · Attlee's answer to Beveridge's "Five Giants".

5.1 The team

Clement Attlee (PM; modest, efficient chairman), **Ernest Bevin** (Foreign Secretary), **Herbert Morrison** (Lord President; nationalisation), **Hugh Dalton** then **Sir Stafford Cripps** then **Hugh Gaitskell** (Chancellors), **Aneurin Bevan** (Health and Housing).

5.2 The problems in 1945

(i) Economic

- Near bankruptcy: debts, sold investments, lost exports (Chapter 4).
- The "**dollar gap**": Britain needed American food, raw materials and machines but could not earn enough dollars.
- **Demobilisation** of about 5 million servicemen; industry to convert from war to peace.
- Costly overseas commitments: Germany, Greece, Palestine, India.

(ii) Social — Beveridge's "Five Giants"

The **Beveridge Report** (1 December 1942), *Social Insurance and Allied Services*, identified five evils to be defeated:

1. **Want** (poverty).
2. **Disease** (poor health care).
3. **Ignorance** (poor education).
4. **Squalor** (bad housing).
5. **Idleness** (unemployment).

5.3 The social reforms — defeating the Five Giants

Giant	Labour's measures
Want	Family Allowances (1945; paid from 1946 , 5s a week for each child after the first); the National Insurance Act (1946) : compulsory insurance for everyone — pensions, sickness, unemployment, maternity, widows' and death benefits; the Industrial Injuries Act (1946) ; the National Assistance Act (1948) : a safety net for those not covered — the end of the Poor Law .
Disease	The National Health Service Act (1946) ; the NHS began on 5 July 1948 : free doctors, hospitals, dentists and opticians for all, paid from taxation. Aneurin Bevan overcame the opposition of the doctors (BMA) — he "stuffed their mouths with gold".
Ignorance	The Butler Education Act (1944) put into effect: free secondary education for all (grammar, secondary modern, technical schools; the eleven-plus); school-leaving age raised to 15 (1947) .
Squalor	About 1 million homes built (1945–51), including about 157,000 "prefabs" ; most were council houses for rent; the New Towns Act (1946) — Stevenage, Harlow, Crawley and others; the Town and Country Planning Act (1947) .
Idleness	Full employment (unemployment about 2–3 per cent); nationalisation; regional policy.

Also: the **Children Act (1948)**; the repeal of the **Trade Disputes Act** of 1927 (**1946**); the **Representation of the People Act (1948)** — the end of plural voting; the **Parliament Act (1949)** — the Lords' delay cut to one year.

5.4 The economic measures

(i) Nationalisation — the "mixed economy"

Year	Industry
1946	The Bank of England ; civil aviation.
1947	Coal (the National Coal Board, 1 January 1947); cable and wireless.
1948	Railways , canals, road haulage (British Transport Commission); electricity .
1949	Gas .
1951	Iron and steel (after a fight with the Lords).

About **20 per cent** of the economy came into public ownership. Owners were compensated.

(ii) Money and trade

- **The US loan (1945, \$3.75 billion)** — with the condition that sterling be made freely **convertible** into dollars.
- **Marshall Aid (1948–51)**: about **\$2.7 billion** — Britain received the largest share of any country.
- **The export drive**: "export or die"; exports rose by about **75 per cent** above the pre-war level by 1950.
- **Austerity** under **Sir Stafford Cripps (1947–50)**: high taxes, controls, rationing continued — **bread** was rationed (**1946–48**), which had never happened in the war.

- **Planning:** controls on investment, materials and prices.

5.5 The economic crises

1. **The fuel crisis (February 1947):** the worst winter of the century; coal could not be moved; power cuts; about 2 million temporarily unemployed.
2. **The convertibility crisis (July–August 1947):** when sterling became convertible (**15 July**), holders rushed to swap pounds for dollars; the loan drained away; convertibility was suspended after five weeks (**20 August**).
3. **Devaluation (September 1949):** the pound was cut from **\$4.03** to **\$2.80** to make exports cheaper.
4. **The Korean War (from 1950):** rearmament of £4.7 billion strained the economy and led **Gaitskell** to impose charges for **dentures and spectacles** (1951); **Bevan** and **Harold Wilson** resigned (**April 1951**), splitting Labour.

5.6 Other achievements

- **India, Pakistan, Burma, Ceylon** independent (1947–48).
- **NATO** (1949) and the British **atomic bomb** programme (decided 1947).
- **The Festival of Britain** (1951).

5.7 Assessment — how successful?

Successes	Failures and limits
The welfare state — lasting, popular, the basis of British life for generations	Repeated economic crises (1947, 1949, 1951)
Full employment throughout	Continued austerity and rationing; public weariness
Exports revived; Marshall Aid used well	Housing targets missed at first; quality sometimes poor
Over a million homes; New Towns	Nationalised industries not modernised; old management
Peaceful independence for India	Investment in industry neglected (Barnett)
A new consensus accepted by the Conservatives	The party split in 1951; lost the election

Historians: **Peter Hennessey** (*Never Again*, 1992) and **Kenneth O. Morgan** (*Labour in Power*, 1984) see a remarkable, lasting achievement; **Correlli Barnett** (*The Audit of War*, 1986; *The Lost Victory*, 1995) argues that Britain built a "**New Jerusalem**" of welfare it could not afford instead of modernising its industry.

The elections: Labour's majority fell to **5** in **1950**; in **1951** Labour won more votes than the Conservatives but fewer seats, and Churchill returned.

WHAT THE EXAMINER HAS ASKED · Where Chapters 4–5 have been asked

2019 Q6 (how successfully Labour tackled the economic and social problems of 1945–51). MCQ
2024: the Bank of England was nationalised in **1946**.

Chapter 6 · Britain in the Cold War: NATO and the Special Relationship

6.1 How the Cold War began

- **Different systems:** the USA (capitalist democracy) and the USSR (communist dictatorship) had been allies only against Hitler.
- **Eastern Europe:** Soviet armies installed communist governments in Poland, Hungary, Romania, Bulgaria and (1948) Czechoslovakia.
- **Churchill's "Iron Curtain" speech (Fulton, 5 March 1946).**
- **Greece and Turkey:** in **February 1947** Britain told the USA it could no longer afford to support Greece and Turkey against communism; the USA took over — the **Truman Doctrine (March 1947)**, promising to help free peoples resist communism.
- **The Marshall Plan (1947–48):** American aid to rebuild Europe; **Bevin** organised the European response.

6.2 Bevin and the making of NATO

- **The Treaty of Dunkirk (1947):** Britain and France against a revived Germany.
- **The Brussels Treaty (March 1948):** Britain, France and the Benelux countries — Western Union.
- **The Berlin Blockade (June 1948 – May 1949):** the Soviets cut off West Berlin; the **Berlin Airlift** by the US and **RAF** flew in supplies for almost a year.
- **NATO — the North Atlantic Treaty**, signed on **4 April 1949** by **12** countries (the USA, Canada, Britain, France, Italy, the Benelux countries, Norway, Denmark, Iceland, Portugal). **Article 5:** an armed attack on one is an attack on all. Bevin was one of its chief architects. Britain has kept forces in Germany ever since.

6.3 Britain's Cold War commitments

- **Nuclear weapons:** Attlee's secret decision (**1947**) — Bevin: "We've got to have the bloody Union Jack on top of it." First British **atomic bomb (October 1952, Monte Bello Islands)**; **hydrogen bomb (1957)**. The **1958 US–UK Mutual Defence Agreement**; the US **Polaris** missile system (**Nassau Agreement, December 1962**, after the US cancelled Skybolt); **Trident** (from 1980).
- **Korea (1950–53):** about **100,000** British troops served; about **1,100** killed (the Glosters at the **Imjin River**, 1951).
- **Malaya (1948–60):** the **Malayan Emergency** against communist guerrillas — won by **General Templer's** "hearts and minds" and the resettlement of villagers (the Briggs Plan).
- **Intelligence:** the **UKUSA Agreement (1946)** — the "**Five Eyes**" partnership with the USA, Canada, Australia and New Zealand.
- **Cuba (1962):** Macmillan was consulted by Kennedy during the missile crisis.
- **Vietnam: Wilson** refused to send troops (1964–68), despite US pressure.

- **"East of Suez"**: after devaluation, Wilson announced (**January 1968**) withdrawal from bases east of Suez (Singapore, Malaysia, the Gulf) by **1971**.

6.4 The special relationship

- **The phrase**: Churchill at Fulton (**1946**).
- **Foundations**: common language and culture, wartime partnership, NATO, nuclear and intelligence cooperation.
- **Strains**: **Suez (1956)** — the USA forced Britain to withdraw; **Skybolt (1962)**; Vietnam; **Heath's** coolness (1970–74) as he turned to Europe; the **Yom Kippur War (1973)**, when Heath refused the US use of British bases.
- **Revivals**: **Macmillan** and **Eisenhower** (Bermuda, 1957), Macmillan and **Kennedy**; later Thatcher and Reagan, Blair and Clinton/Bush (Topic 9).

6.5 Subservient to the USA? — the long view (1945–2026)

THE "SPECIAL RELATIONSHIP": JUNIOR PARTNER OR POODLE?

Moments of dependence and independence, 1945–2025

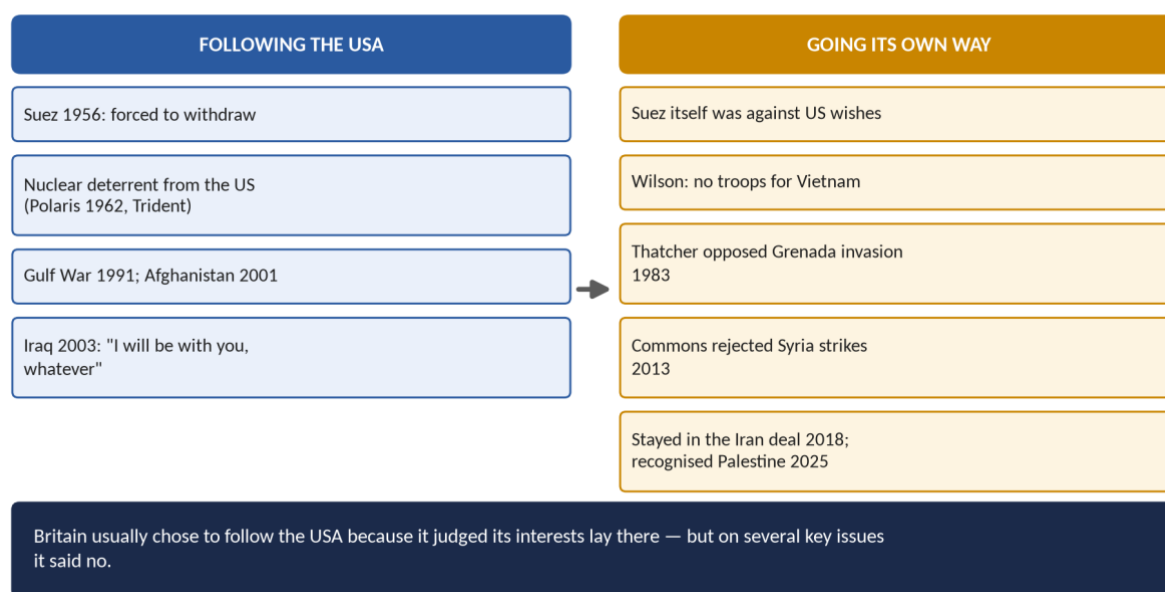


Figure 5 · The special relationship: junior partner or poodle?

(i) Why some believe Britain was subservient

1. **Money**: the US loan (1945), Marshall Aid, and the US pressure on sterling at **Suez (1956)** showed Britain could not act against America.
2. **Nuclear dependence**: Polaris (1962) and **Trident** — Britain's deterrent depends on US missiles.
3. **Bases**: US bombers and missiles in Britain (Greenham Common's cruise missiles, 1983); the **Libya bombing (1986)** launched from British bases.
4. **Wars**: the **Gulf War (1991)**; **Kosovo (1999)**; **Afghanistan** (from **October 2001**) after 9/11 — Blair pledged to stand "**shoulder to shoulder**" with America.

5. **Iraq (2003):** Blair joined the US invasion despite mass protests (about 1 million marched in London, February 2003) and no second UN resolution. The **Chilcot Report (July 2016)** revealed his note to President Bush (**July 2002**): "**I will be with you, whatever.**" Critics called him "**Bush's poodle**".
6. **Unequal treaties:** the **2003 Extradition Treaty** was said to favour the USA.

(ii) Evidence of independence

1. **Suez** itself (1956) was launched **against** US wishes.
2. **Vietnam:** Wilson refused troops.
3. **Heath** put **Europe** first; he denied the US bases in 1973.
4. **Thatcher** protested at the US invasion of **Grenada** (a Commonwealth country, **1983**) and opposed parts of Reagan's nuclear plans after Reykjavik (1986).
5. **Blair** pressed Bush to go to the **UN** (Resolution 1441, November 2002) and to pursue the Middle East peace process.
6. **Syria (August 2013):** the **Commons voted against** military action (285 to 272); Britain did not join US strikes then.
7. **China:** Britain joined the China-led **Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (2015)** against US wishes.
8. **Iran:** Britain stayed in the **Iran nuclear deal** after the US left it (**2018**) — though in **2025** Britain, France and Germany triggered the return of UN sanctions.
9. **Palestine:** Britain **recognised the State of Palestine (September 2025)**, a step the US opposed.

(iii) Explaining the pattern

Britain has usually followed the USA because it judged that its **interests** — security, nuclear and intelligence cooperation, influence in Washington — lay there, and because the two countries shared **values**. "Hugging close" was a deliberate strategy to gain influence. So Britain has been a **dependent** partner, often too willing to follow, but not a **servant**: when its interests or Parliament disagreed, it said no. Recent examples of partnership by choice include **AUKUS (2021, with Australia and the USA)** and support for **Ukraine (from 2022)**.

WHAT THE EXAMINER HAS ASKED · Where Chapter 6 has been asked

2018 Q7: why some believe Britain was subservient to the US line during the Cold War and after 9/11 — do you agree?

Chapter 7 · The Commonwealth

EMPIRE AND COMMONWEALTH COMPARED

From rule to free association

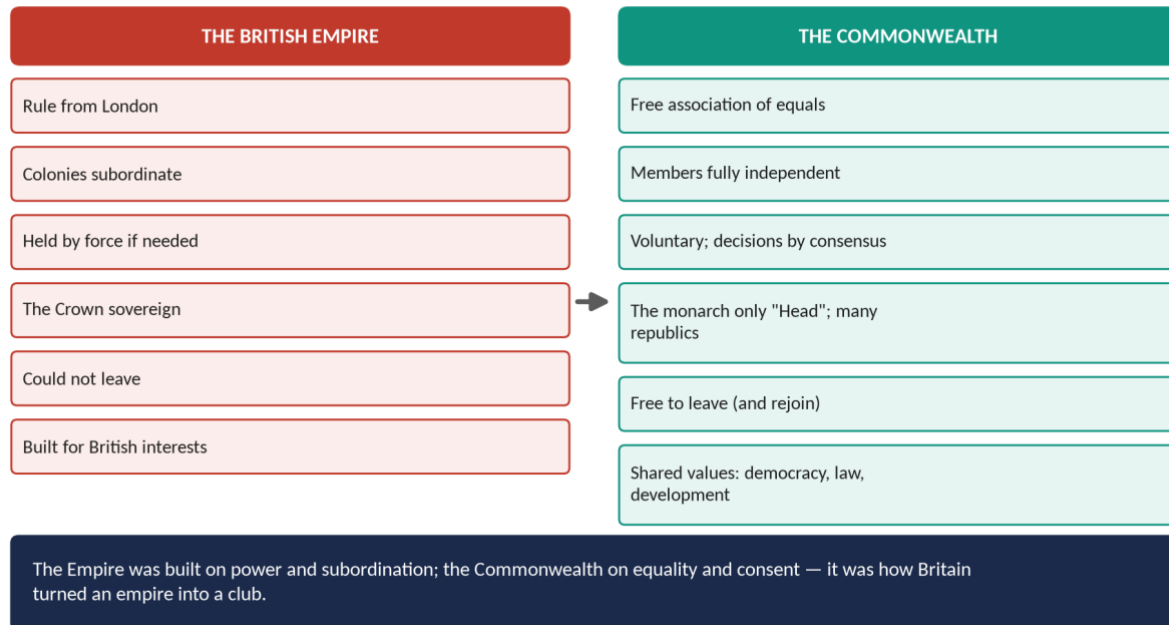


Figure 6 · Empire and Commonwealth compared.

7.1 What is the Commonwealth?

The **Commonwealth of Nations** is a **voluntary association** of **56** independent and equal countries, almost all of them former parts of the British Empire, which cooperate on the basis of shared values — democracy, human rights, the rule of law, development. The British monarch (now **King Charles III**) is its symbolic **Head**. It has about **2.7 billion** people — about a third of the world's population.

7.2 The development of the idea — stage by stage

Stage 1 · Self-government for the settler colonies (1839–1914)

- **The Durham Report (1839)**, after rebellions in Canada, recommended **responsible government** — colonial ministers answerable to their own elected assemblies.
- **The Dominions: Canada (1867), Australia (1901), New Zealand (1907), Newfoundland (1907), South Africa (1910)** — self-governing in domestic affairs, though Britain still controlled foreign policy.
- **The phrase:** Lord **Rosebery (1884)** described the Empire as "**a commonwealth of nations**".
- **Colonial Conferences** (from **1887**), later **Imperial Conferences** (1907).

Stage 2 · From Dominions to equals (1914–1931)

- **The First World War:** the Dominions sent over a million men; they signed the peace treaties and joined the **League of Nations** separately.
- **Jan Smuts** (South Africa) spoke of the "**British Commonwealth of Nations**" (1917); the term appeared in the **Anglo-Irish Treaty** (1921); the **Irish Free State** became a Dominion (1922).
- **Chanak** (1922): the Dominions refused to follow Britain into war automatically.
- **The Balfour Declaration** (1926) defined Britain and the Dominions as "**autonomous communities within the British Empire, equal in status, in no way subordinate one to another in any aspect of their domestic or external affairs, though united by a common allegiance to the Crown, and freely associated as members of the British Commonwealth of Nations**".
- **The Statute of Westminster** (11 December 1931) gave this legal force: British laws no longer applied to a Dominion unless it asked; the Dominions were fully **sovereign**.

Stage 3 · The modern, multiracial Commonwealth (1947–1965)

- **India, Pakistan and Ceylon** (1947–48) joined as the first **non-white** members; Burma (1948) did not join.
- **The London Declaration** (April 1949): **India** wished to become a **republic** but stay a member. The prime ministers agreed that a republic could remain in, recognising the King as "**the symbol of the free association of its independent member nations and as such the Head of the Commonwealth**". The word "**British**" was dropped — it became simply the **Commonwealth of Nations**. This is often called the **creation of the modern Commonwealth**.
- **Ireland** left (1949) on becoming a republic.
- **Decolonisation** (1957 onwards): new African, Asian and Caribbean states joined — Ghana and Malaya (1957), Nigeria (1960) and many more. The white Dominions became a minority.
- **South Africa** left in 1961 over **apartheid** (it rejoined in 1994 after Mandela's election).
- **The Commonwealth Secretariat** (1965) in London; first Secretary-General **Arnold Smith** (Canada). The Commonwealth became an organisation of members, not a British institution.

Stage 4 · A community of values (1971–2026)

- **The Singapore Declaration** (1971): shared principles — peace, liberty, racial equality.
- **The Gleneagles Agreement** (1977): a sporting boycott of apartheid South Africa.
- **The Harare Declaration** (1991): democracy, human rights, good governance.
- **Enforcement:** members suspended for military coups or abuses (Nigeria 1995; **Zimbabwe** 2002, which left in 2003; Pakistan 1999; Fiji).
- **The Commonwealth Charter** (2013): sixteen core values.
- **New members with no British colonial link:** **Mozambique** (1995), **Rwanda** (2009), **Gabon** and **Togo** (2022).
- **Headship:** Elizabeth II (1952–2022) — the members agreed in 2018 that **Charles** would succeed her; **King Charles III** became Head in 2022.

- **Today: 56** members; the Commonwealth Games; scholarships; trade; small-state support; the CHOGM in **Samoa (2024)** — the first in the Pacific — discussed **reparatory justice** for slavery; Secretary-General **Shirley Botchwey** (Ghana) from **2025**.

7.3 How the Commonwealth differs from the Empire

Point	British Empire	Commonwealth
Basis	Conquest, settlement, treaty — power	Voluntary free association — consent
Status	Colonies subordinate to Britain	Members equal and fully sovereign
Government	Ruled or supervised from London (Colonial Office, Viceroy, Governors)	Each member governs itself; a Secretariat serves them all
The Crown	Sovereign ruler of all	Symbolic Head ; most members are republics or have their own monarchs
Force	Maintained by armies when needed (India 1857, Kenya)	No force; members can leave freely and rejoin (Pakistan, South Africa)
Decisions	British decisions	Consensus at meetings (CHOGM)
Purpose	British trade, strategy, prestige	Cooperation, development, democracy, shared values
Membership	British possessions only	Includes states that were never British colonies (Mozambique, Rwanda)
Character	Led and dominated by Britain; racially hierarchical	Multiracial ; the majority in Africa, Asia, the Caribbean and Pacific

7.4 The significance of the Commonwealth

- **It eased the end of empire:** Britain could present decolonisation as an evolution, not a defeat, and new states kept links with Britain.
- **Influence, not power:** diplomacy, trade, education, legal systems and the English language.
- **Moral leadership:** the struggle against **apartheid** and **Rhodesian** white-minority rule.
- **Limits:** no binding powers; Britain's own turn to **Europe** (1973) weakened trade links; critics call it a talking shop or a relic of empire; debates on slavery reparations.

WHAT THE EXAMINER HAS ASKED · Where Chapter 7 has been asked

2015 P-II Q6 (how the idea developed; how it differs from the Empire) · **2017 Q7** (the same) · **2024 Q7(c)** (short note: the creation of the Commonwealth).

Chapter 8 · Decolonisation

8.1 What decolonisation means

Decolonisation is the process by which colonies gained independence from their colonial rulers. Britain's empire in **1945** covered about **700 million** people; by **1970** most of it had gone, and by **1997** (Hong Kong) almost all.

THE END OF EMPIRE: INDEPENDENCE DATES

Numbers are keyed to the table beside the map in the text

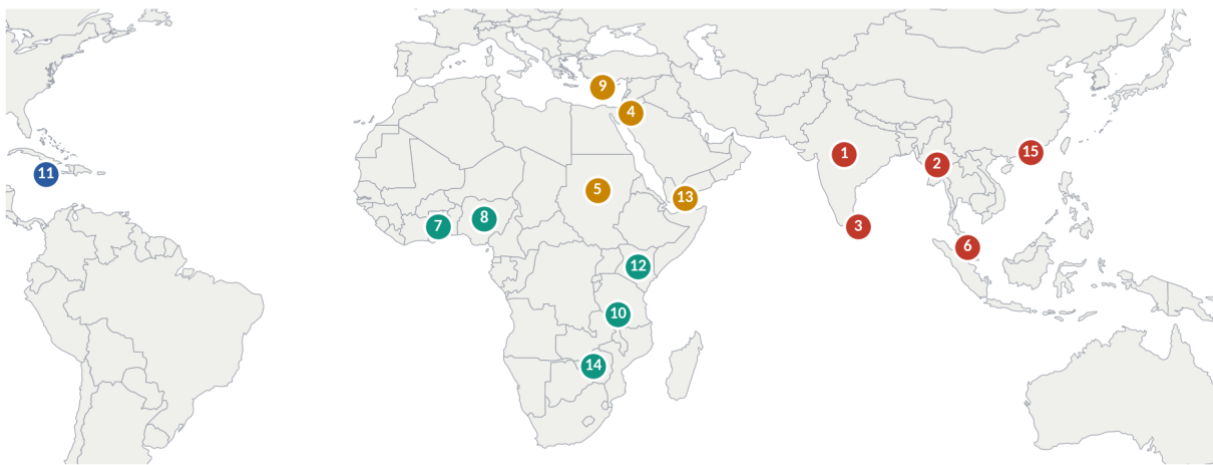


Figure 7 · The end of empire: numbered independence dates (key below).

1	India and Pakistan	1947	9	Cyprus	1960
2	Burma	1948	10	Tanganyika (Tanzania)	1961
3	Ceylon (Sri Lanka)	1948	11	Jamaica	1962
4	Palestine (mandate ended)	1948	12	Kenya	1963
5	Sudan	1956	13	Aden (South Yemen)	1967
6	Malaya	1957	14	Rhodesia → Zimbabwe	1980
7	Gold Coast → Ghana	1957	15	Hong Kong (to China)	1997
8	Nigeria	1960			

8.2 The motives — why Britain decolonised

WHY THE EMPIRE ENDED

Global pressures, British weakness and choices made in London

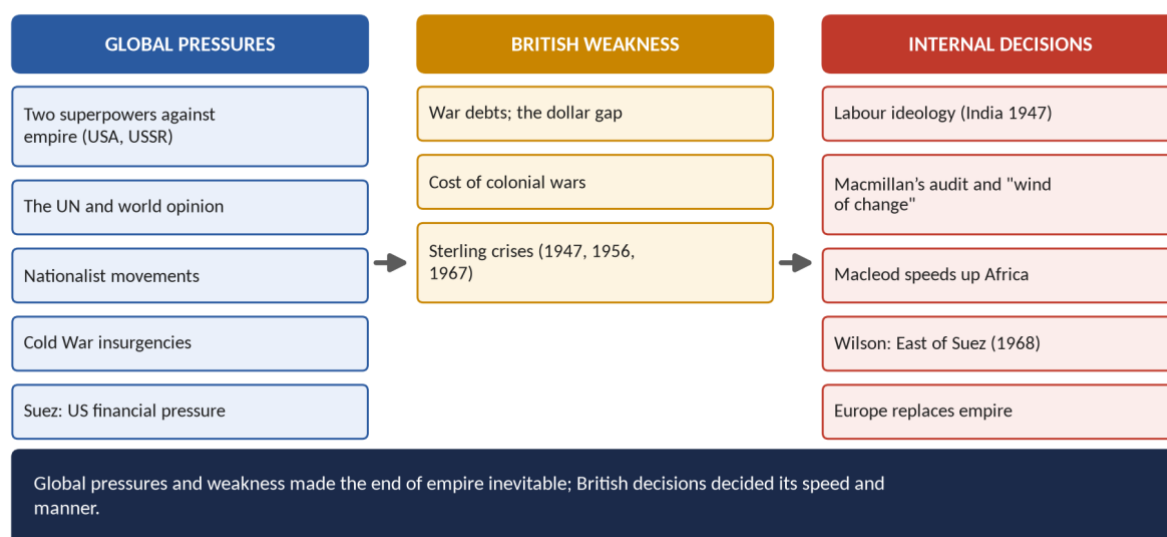


Figure 8 · Why the Empire ended.

(i) Economic weakness

- Britain was deeply in **debt** after 1945; it could not afford to hold down colonies by force.
- Colonial wars were expensive: **Malaya, Kenya, Cyprus, Aden**.
- Repeated **sterling crises** (1947, 1949, 1956, 1967).

(ii) Nationalism

Strong nationalist movements — the Indian **Congress** and **Muslim League**, **Nkrumah's** Convention People's Party in the Gold Coast, **Kenyatta's** KANU in Kenya — made colonial rule impossible without force.

(iii) The Second World War

The fall of **Singapore** (1942) destroyed British prestige; the **Atlantic Charter** and colonial soldiers' service raised expectations; India was promised independence.

(iv) International pressure

- **The USA** opposed old-style empires (Roosevelt; Eisenhower at **Suez**).
- **The USSR** supported "national liberation" movements.
- **The United Nations**: its Charter proclaimed self-determination; the **Declaration on the Granting of Independence to Colonial Countries and Peoples** (Resolution 1514, December 1960).

(v) The Cold War

Britain needed to hand power to **moderate, pro-Western** nationalists before communists took over (Malaya); fighting colonial wars damaged its image; resources were needed for NATO and nuclear weapons.

(vi) British decisions and attitudes

- **Labour's** anti-imperial ideals (India, 1947).
- **Macmillan's** audit of the colonies' costs and benefits (1957) and his "**wind of change**" speech (**Cape Town, 3 February 1960**): "The wind of change is blowing through this continent, and whether we like it or not, this growth of national consciousness is a political fact."
- **Iain Macleod** (Colonial Secretary, 1959–61) speeded up independence in Africa.
- **Suez (1956)** showed Britain could no longer act as an imperial power.
- **Europe**: from 1961 Britain looked to the EEC rather than the empire.
- **Public opinion** was largely indifferent; scandals such as the **Hola camp** killings in Kenya (**March 1959**, 11 detainees beaten to death) and the **Devlin Report** on Nyasaland (1959: "a police state") turned opinion against colonial rule.

(vii) The Commonwealth as a bridge

Independence within the Commonwealth let Britain keep friendship and influence.

8.3 India, 1947

(i) Why Britain left

1. **Indian nationalism**: the **Indian National Congress** (1885) under **Gandhi** and **Nehru**, with mass campaigns of non-cooperation (1920–22), civil disobedience (the **Salt March**, 1930), and **Quit India (August 1942)**.
2. **The Muslim League** under **Jinnah** demanded a separate homeland — the **Lahore Resolution (23 March 1940)**; the League won almost all Muslim seats in the **1945–46** elections.
3. **The war** weakened Britain; **Cripps** had promised independence after the war (1942); India became Britain's **creditor** (the sterling balances).
4. **Loss of control**: the **INA trials** (1945–46, of soldiers of Subhas Chandra Bose's Indian National Army) roused huge public sympathy; the **Royal Indian Navy mutiny (February 1946)** showed the armed forces could no longer be relied on; the **Indian Civil Service** was now largely Indian.
5. **Labour's commitment**: Attlee and his colleagues believed in Indian independence.
6. **US pressure** and world opinion.
7. **Cost**: holding India by force would need troops Britain did not have.

(ii) How Britain left

Date	Step
March 1942	The Cripps Mission: dominion status after the war, with the right of provinces to opt out; rejected ("a post-dated cheque on a failing bank", as Gandhi reportedly called it).
Aug 1942	Quit India; Congress leaders imprisoned for the rest of the war.
June–July 1945	The Simla Conference (Viceroy Wavell) failed over Muslim representation.
1945–46	Elections: Congress won the general seats, the League almost all Muslim seats.
Mar–June 1946	The Cabinet Mission (Pethick-Lawrence, Cripps, Alexander): a loose federal union with three groups of provinces (the 16 May plan); first accepted by the League, then collapsed over interpretation.
16 Aug 1946	Direct Action Day called by the League; the Great Calcutta Killings — about 4,000 dead; violence spread to Noakhali, Bihar and the Punjab.
Sept 1946	An interim government under Nehru ; the League joined in October but cooperation failed.
20 Feb 1947	Attlee announced that Britain would leave by June 1948 .
Mar 1947	Lord Mountbatten became the last Viceroy .
3 June 1947	The 3 June Plan (Mountbatten Plan): partition into India and Pakistan, with Bengal and the Punjab divided; the date brought forward to August 1947 .
July 1947	The Indian Independence Act (royal assent 18 July).
14–15 Aug 1947	Pakistan (14 August) and India (15 August) became independent Dominions .
17 Aug 1947	The Radcliffe Line borders announced.

(iii) The consequences

- **Partition violence:** an estimated **several hundred thousand to over a million** killed; about **12–15 million** people displaced — one of the largest migrations in history.
- **The princely states** joined India or Pakistan; **Kashmir** became a lasting source of conflict (war 1947–48).
- **Gandhi** was assassinated (**January 1948**).
- Both new states stayed in the **Commonwealth**; India's wish to be a republic led to the **London Declaration** (1949).
- **Judgement:** Britain's speed avoided being caught in a civil war and a costly holding operation, but critics blame the rushed timetable (Mountbatten) and the hasty borders for the scale of the slaughter.

8.4 Other major cases

(i) Malaya (1948–1957)

A communist insurgency (mainly among the Chinese population) was defeated in the **Malayan Emergency** through military action, resettlement and a promise of independence; **Malaya** became independent on **31 August 1957** under **Tunku Abdul Rahman**; **Malaysia** (with Singapore, Sarawak and Sabah) formed in **1963**; **Singapore** separated in **1965**.

(ii) The Gold Coast → Ghana (1957)

Kwame Nkrumah's mass party won elections (1951, 1954, 1956); the first **sub-Saharan** colony to win independence (**6 March 1957**) — a model for the rest of Africa.

(iii) Kenya (1952–1963)

- A settler colony with white farmers in the "White Highlands".
- **The Mau Mau rising (1952–60)** among the **Kikuyu**: about 11,000 rebels and some 2,000 loyalist Africans killed, 32 white settlers; tens of thousands of Kikuyu held in detention camps; the **Hola camp** killings (**1959**).
- **Macleod** and the **Lancaster House conferences** (1960, 1962) moved to majority rule; **Jomo Kenyatta**, once imprisoned, became leader; independence on **12 December 1963**.
- In **2013** the British government paid **£19.9 million** to about 5,000 Kenyan victims of abuse.

(iv) The wind of change (1960–1966)

Nigeria (1960), **Cyprus** (1960, after the EOKA insurgency), **Sierra Leone** (1961), **Tanganyika** (1961), **Uganda** (1962), **Jamaica** and **Trinidad** (1962), **Kenya** (1963), **Malawi** and **Zambia** (1964, after the break-up of the Central African Federation), **Gambia** (1965), **Botswana** and **Lesotho** (1966).

(v) Aden (1967)

Britain's base at **Aden** guarded the route to India and the Gulf. A nationalist insurgency (1963–67) and the **1966 Defence Review** led to a hasty withdrawal (**November 1967**).

(vi) Rhodesia (1965–1980)

The white minority under **Ian Smith** declared **UDI** (Unilateral Declaration of Independence) on **11 November 1965** to avoid majority rule. Wilson refused to use force; UN sanctions failed; a guerrilla war followed. The **Lancaster House Agreement (December 1979)** led to elections and the independence of **Zimbabwe (18 April 1980)** under **Robert Mugabe**.

(vii) Hong Kong (1997)

The lease on the **New Territories** expired in **1997**. The **Sino-British Joint Declaration (1984)** agreed the return of all Hong Kong to China under "**one country, two systems**" for 50 years; handover on **1 July 1997**.

8.5 Global pressures or British decisions? — weighing the causes

Case	Global pressures	British decisions
India 1947	Nationalism; war weakness; US and world opinion	Attlee's ideology and deadline (Feb 1947); Mountbatten's timetable
Suez 1956	US financial pressure on sterling; UN; USSR	Eden's decision to invade — and to withdraw

Case	Global pressures	British decisions
Ghana 1957	Nationalism; example for Africa	Colonial Office's gradual plan with Nkrumah
Kenya 1963	Mau Mau; world opinion after Hola	Macleod's decision to move fast to majority rule
Aden 1967	Insurgency; Arab nationalism	The 1966 Defence Review; economy cuts
East of Suez 1968	Sterling crisis; US involvement in Asia	Wilson's decision after devaluation
Hong Kong 1997	China's power; the lease	Thatcher's negotiated Joint Declaration (1984)

Judgement: global pressures and British weakness set the **direction** — empire could not last; British political decisions set the **pace** and **manner** — fast or slow, peaceful or violent, within the Commonwealth or not.

WHAT THE EXAMINER HAS ASKED · Where Chapter 8 has been asked

2019 Q7 (motives; why and how Britain left India) · **2024 Q6** (how WWII and the Cold War triggered decolonisation) · **2026 Q4** (global pressures v internal decisions, with three cases). MCQs **2025:** former colonies gained independence through **decolonisation**; **2024:** apartheid was in **South Africa**.

Chapter 9 · The Middle East, Palestine and Suez

BRITAIN IN THE MIDDLE EAST, 1945–1971

Palestine, Suez and the retreat from east of Suez

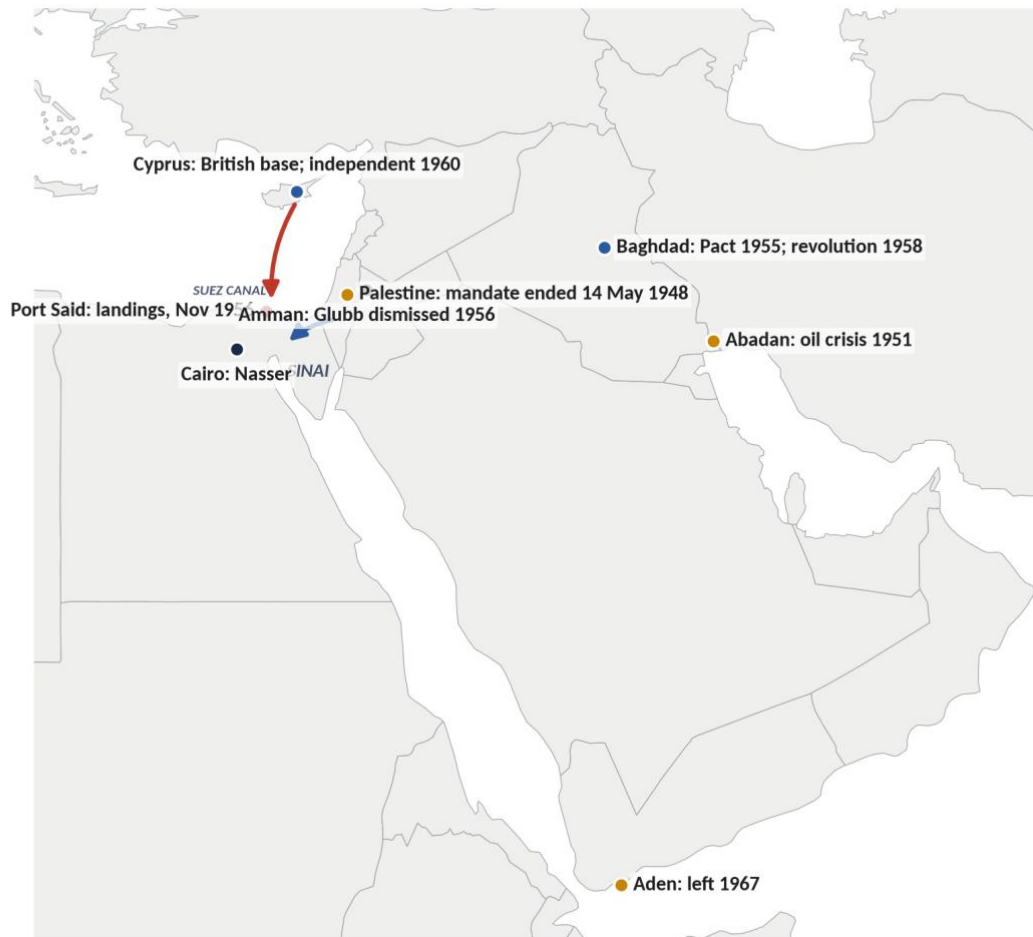


Figure 9 · Britain in the Middle East, 1945–1971.

9.1 Britain in the Middle East

- **Interests:** the **Suez Canal** (route to India and the East), **oil** (Iran, Iraq, the Gulf), bases (Egypt, Cyprus, Aden, Iraq), and keeping out the USSR.
- **After 1918:** League **mandates** over **Palestine**, **Transjordan** and **Iraq**; British influence over **Egypt** (independent in name from 1922; the **Anglo-Egyptian Treaty**, 1936, kept British troops in the Canal Zone).
- **After 1945:** rising **Arab nationalism**; the Cold War.

9.2 Palestine (1917–1948)

(i) The problem Britain created

- **The McMahon–Hussein correspondence** (1915–16) seemed to promise Arab independence.

- **The Balfour Declaration (2 November 1917)** promised "a national home for the Jewish people" in Palestine, without prejudice to the rights of the existing non-Jewish communities.
- **The Mandate (1920, confirmed 1922)**: Jewish immigration grew, especially after Hitler came to power (1933).

(ii) The inter-war conflict

- **The Arab Revolt (1936–39)** against Jewish immigration and British rule.
- **The Peel Commission (1937)** proposed **partition**.
- **The 1939 White Paper** limited Jewish immigration to **75,000** over five years and promised an independent, Arab-majority Palestine within ten years — angering the Zionists.

(iii) Why Britain withdrew (1945–1948)

1. **Jewish insurgency**: the **Irgun** and **Lehi** ("Stern Gang") attacked the British; the **King David Hotel bombing (22 July 1946, 91 killed)**; the hanging of two British sergeants (1947).
2. **Impossible promises**: Arabs and Jews wanted opposite things; any policy angered one side.
3. **US pressure**: President **Truman** demanded the admission of **100,000** Jewish refugees, survivors of the Holocaust; the **Exodus** affair (1947) shamed Britain.
4. **Cost**: about **100,000** troops were tied down at a time of economic crisis.
5. **Bevin referred** the problem to the UN (**February 1947**).
6. **UN partition: Resolution 181 (29 November 1947)** proposed separate Jewish and Arab states and an international Jerusalem; Britain abstained and refused to enforce it.
7. **Withdrawal**: the mandate ended on **14–15 May 1948**; **Israel** was proclaimed on **14 May**; the first Arab–Israeli war followed; about **700,000** Palestinians fled or were expelled (the **Nakba**).

9.3 Other crises of influence

- **Iran (1951–53)**: **Mossadegh** nationalised the **Anglo-Iranian Oil Company** (Abadan); an Anglo-American-backed coup overthrew him (**1953**).
- **The Baghdad Pact (1955)**: Britain, Turkey, Iraq, Iran and Pakistan against Soviet influence.
- **Jordan**: King Hussein dismissed the British commander **Glubb Pasha (March 1956)**.
- **Iraq**: the pro-British monarchy was overthrown (**July 1958**).

9.4 The Suez Crisis (1956)

(i) The background

- **The canal:** opened **1869**; Britain bought the Khedive's shares (**1875**) and occupied Egypt (**1882**). In the 1950s two-thirds of Europe's oil came through it.
- **Nasser:** Colonel **Gamal Abdel Nasser** came to power after the 1952 revolution; a hero of **Arab nationalism**.
- **The 1954 agreement:** Britain agreed to withdraw its troops from the **Canal Zone** within 20 months; the last left in **June 1956**.
- **Tension:** Nasser opposed the **Baghdad Pact**; bought **Czech (Soviet-bloc) arms** (1955); supported Algerian rebels against France and raids into Israel.
- **The Aswan Dam:** the USA and Britain withdrew their offer of loans for Nasser's great dam (**19 July 1956**).

(ii) The crisis

Date	Event
26 July 1956	Nasser nationalised the Suez Canal Company to pay for the dam.
Aug–Oct 1956	Conferences in London; the Suez Canal Users' Association; negotiations at the UN. Eden , who compared Nasser with Mussolini, prepared military action with France.
22–24 Oct 1956	The secret Protocol of Sèvres : Britain, France and Israel agreed that Israel would attack Egypt, giving Britain and France an excuse to intervene to "separate the combatants" and seize the canal.
29 Oct	Israel invaded Sinai .
30 Oct	The Anglo-French ultimatum to both sides to withdraw from the canal.
31 Oct	British and French aircraft bombed Egyptian airfields; Nasser blocked the canal with sunken ships.
2 Nov	The UN General Assembly, on a US motion, demanded a ceasefire (64 to 5).
5–6 Nov	Operation Musketeer : British and French paratroops and seaborne forces landed at Port Said and advanced along the canal.
5 Nov	The USSR threatened rocket attacks on London and Paris (Hungary was being crushed at the same time).
6 Nov	Facing a run on the pound and US refusal to support an IMF loan unless Britain stopped, Eden accepted a ceasefire at midnight.
Nov–Dec	A UN Emergency Force (proposed by Canada's Lester Pearson) took over; British and French forces left by 22 December 1956 .
9 Jan 1957	Eden resigned (officially for ill health); Macmillan became PM.

(iii) Why Britain withdrew from Suez

1. **US opposition** — decisive: **Eisenhower** was furious at not being consulted, feared driving the Arab world to the USSR, and was fighting an election; the US **refused financial help** while sterling was under attack.
2. **The run on sterling:** Britain was losing its reserves; oil supplies were cut.

3. **The UN:** almost the whole world condemned the invasion.
4. **The Soviet threat.**
5. **The Commonwealth** was divided (India, Canada opposed).
6. **Opposition at home:** Labour (Gaitskell) and part of the press and public; two ministers resigned.

(iv) Consequences

- **The end of Britain as an independent great power:** it could not act against US wishes.
- **The special relationship** was repaired by **Macmillan** — Britain would never again oppose the USA on a major issue.
- **Faster decolonisation:** Macmillan's audit, the "wind of change".
- **France** turned towards Europe (the **Treaty of Rome**, 1957) and its own nuclear force.
- **Nasser** became the hero of the Arab world; British influence in the Middle East declined (Iraq 1958, Aden 1967, the Gulf 1971).
- **The Eisenhower Doctrine (1957):** the USA replaced Britain as the Western power in the Middle East.

WHAT THE EXAMINER HAS ASKED · Where Chapter 9 has been asked

2020 Q6 (the Middle East and Suez; why England withdrew from Palestine and the canal) · **2022 Q8(b)** (short note: the Suez Crisis). MCQ **2026:** the Suez Crisis resulted in **British withdrawal**.

Chapter 10 · Home and Europe, 1951–1979

10.1 The Conservative years (1951–1964)

- **Churchill** (1951–55): accepted the welfare state; denationalised **steel** and **road haulage**; **300,000** houses a year (1953); rationing ended (**4 July 1954**); the **coronation** of **Elizabeth II** (**2 June 1953**).
- **Eden** (1955–57): Suez.
- **Macmillan** (1957–63): the "**affluent society**" — cars, televisions, washing machines; "**Most of our people have never had it so good**" (**July 1957**); "**stop-go**" economics; the **Profumo affair** (1963).
- **Home** (1963–64).
- "**Butskellism**": both parties accepted the welfare state, full employment and a mixed economy.

10.2 The Wilson years (1964–1970)

- "**The white heat of technology**" (1963).
- **Devaluation** (**November 1967**): \$2.80 → **\$2.40**; "the pound in your pocket" has not been devalued.
- **Social reforms**: the Open University, the abolition of hanging, the Race Relations Acts, the Equal Pay Act (1970).
- "**Swinging London**": the Beatles, fashion (Carnaby Street, the miniskirt), *Time* magazine's cover "**London: The Swinging City**" (**April 1966**).
- **In Place of Strife** (1969): a plan to reform unions — dropped after opposition.
- **Northern Ireland**: the **Troubles** began (1968–69); troops sent (August 1969).

10.3 Heath (1970–1974)

- **EEC entry** (**1 January 1973**).
- **Decimal currency** (**15 February 1971**).
- **The Industrial Relations Act** (1971); **miners' strikes** (**1972, 1974**); the oil crisis (1973); the **three-day week** (**January–March 1974**); "Who governs Britain?" — Heath lost the February 1974 election.

10.4 Wilson and Callaghan (1974–1979)

- **The EEC referendum** (**5 June 1975**): **67 per cent** voted to stay in.
- **Inflation** reached about **25 per cent** (1975).
- **The IMF loan** (**1976**): **\$3.9 billion**, in return for spending cuts — a national humiliation.
- **The Lib-Lab Pact** (1977–78).

- **The Winter of Discontent (1978–79)**: strikes by lorry drivers, public-sector workers, refuse collectors and gravediggers against the government's 5 per cent pay limit; "**Crisis? What crisis?**" (*The Sun*'s headline about **James Callaghan**, January 1979).
- **The fall**: the government lost a vote of no confidence by **one vote** (311 to 310, **28 March 1979**); **Margaret Thatcher** won the election of **May 1979**.

10.5 Britain and the EEC

Year	Event
1950–51	Britain stayed out of the Schuman Plan (the European Coal and Steel Community).
1957	The Treaty of Rome created the EEC (France, West Germany, Italy, the Benelux countries); Britain stayed out, preferring the Commonwealth, the USA and national sovereignty.
1960	Britain formed EFTA (the European Free Trade Association) with six other states — much weaker.
1961	Macmillan applied to join (negotiator Edward Heath) — after Suez, slow growth and the decline of Commonwealth trade.
14 Jan 1963	De Gaulle's veto ("Non!"): Britain was too tied to the USA (the Nassau deal) and its Commonwealth, and "insular".
1967	Wilson applied again — vetoed by de Gaulle (November 1967).
1969	De Gaulle resigned; Pompidou was more open.
1972–73	Heath negotiated entry; Britain joined on 1 January 1973 with Ireland and Denmark.
1975	Referendum : 67% Yes.
2016–2020	The story continues in Topics 9–10: the Brexit referendum (2016) and departure (31 January 2020).

Chapter 11 · The Legacy — to 2026

Theme	What happened later
The Second World War	80th anniversaries of VE and VJ Day in 2025 ; the war remains central to British identity.
Churchill	Voted "Greatest Briton" (2002); debates about his imperial record continue.
The welfare state	The NHS celebrated its 75th anniversary in 2023 ; still the most valued British institution in polls, and under constant strain.
NATO	Still Britain's defence cornerstone; enlarged to 32 members (Finland 2023, Sweden 2024) after Russia's invasion of Ukraine; members agreed in 2025 to aim at defence spending of 5 per cent of GDP by 2035.
The special relationship	AUKUS (2021); Ukraine; tensions over trade and tariffs under President Trump (2025).
The Commonwealth	56 members; King Charles III Head; Samoa CHOGM (2024).
Decolonisation	The Chagos Islands agreement (signed 2025) to hand sovereignty to Mauritius while keeping the Diego Garcia base on a long lease — one of the last acts of decolonisation.
Suez and the Middle East	Britain's role is now as a partner of the USA and Europe; it recognised Palestine (2025) .
Europe	Britain joined in 1973, voted to leave in 2016 , left in 2020 , and under Starmer sought a " reset " with the EU (the May 2025 summit agreements).

Part Four — Historians and Quotations

Historian	The view to quote
A. J. P. Taylor , <i>The Origins of the Second World War</i> (1961)	Hitler an opportunist; Western mistakes.
Richard Overy , <i>Why the Allies Won</i> (1995)	Production, technology and morale won the war.
Martin Gilbert , Roy Jenkins , Andrew Roberts	Admiring biographies of Churchill.
Clive Ponting , John Charmley	Critics: Churchill's mistakes and the cost of total victory.
Peter Hennessy , <i>Never Again</i> (1992)	The Attlee government's remarkable achievement.
Correlli Barnett , <i>The Audit of War</i> (1986)	The "New Jerusalem" at the expense of industrial renewal.
Kenneth O. Morgan , <i>Labour in Power</i> (1984)	Labour's most successful government.
John Darwin , <i>The Empire Project</i> (2009)	Decolonisation driven by global changes; empire always depended on a favourable world order.
R. Hyam , <i>Britain's Declining Empire</i> (2006)	British decisions and management of decline.
W. R. Louis	The USA and the end of the British Empire.
Keith Kyle , <i>Suez</i> (1991)	The crisis as the end of British independence of action.
Yasmin Khan , <i>The Great Partition</i> (2007)	The human cost of 1947.

"I have nothing to offer but blood, toil, tears and sweat." — **Churchill**, 13 May 1940

"Never in the field of human conflict was so much owed by so many to so few." — **Churchill**, 20 August 1940

"An iron curtain has descended across the Continent." — **Churchill**, Fulton, 5 March 1946

"The wind of change is blowing through this continent." — **Macmillan**, Cape Town, 3 February 1960

"Great Britain has lost an empire and has not yet found a role." — **Dean Acheson**, 1962

Part Five — The Examiner's Record

Paper	The question as set	Family	Type
2015 · Q6 · Paper II	How has the idea of the British Commonwealth of Nations developed? In what ways does its significance differ from the term British Empire?	The Commonwealth	Compare / contrast
2016 · Q8(a) · Section B	<i>Short note:</i> Second World War	The Second World War and Churchill	Short note
2017 · Q7 · Section B	What do you understand by the British Commonwealth of Nations and how did it develop? How does it differ from the term British Empire?	The Commonwealth	Compare / contrast
2018 · Q7 · Section B	Why is it believed in certain circles that after decolonisation Britain was subservient to the US line of action during the Cold War and thereafter, down to 9/11 and subsequent years? Do you agree or not? Argue.	The special relationship with the USA	How far / extent
2018 · Q8(a) · Section B	<i>Short note:</i> Sir Winston Churchill	The Second World War and Churchill	Short note
2019 · Q6 · Section B	How successfully did the Labour government of 1945–51 tackle the economic and social problems of post-World War II Britain?	Attlee's Labour government 1945–51	How far / extent
2019 · Q7 · Section B	What were the motives behind Britain's move to decolonisation after 1945? Also explain why and how the British left India in 1947.	Decolonisation, India, Palestine, Suez	Causes / results
2020 · Q6 · Section B	What do you know about the Middle East and Suez Canal Crisis? Also explain why England withdrew from Palestine and the Suez Canal. Discuss.	Decolonisation, India, Palestine, Suez	Causes / results
2022 · Q7 · Section B	Discuss Winston Churchill as a statesman, warrior and a man of letters.	The Second World War and Churchill	Person
2022 · Q8(b) · Section B	<i>Short note:</i> Suez Canal Crisis	Decolonisation, India, Palestine, Suez	Short note
2023 · Q6 · Section B	Produce an analytical essay on the causes, major developments and aftermath of the Second World War.	The Second World War and Churchill	Causes / results
2024 · Q6 · Section B	How did World War II and the Cold War trigger the decolonization of the British Empire?	Decolonisation, India, Palestine, Suez	Causes / results
2024 · Q7(c) · Section B	<i>Short note:</i> Creation of the Commonwealth	The Commonwealth	Short note
2026 · Q4 · Section A	How far was the decline of the British Empire after 1945 the result of global pressures rather than internal political decisions? Support your analysis with at least three major real end-of-decolonisation cases.	Decolonisation, India, Palestine, Suez	How far / extent

WHAT THE EXAMINER HAS ASKED · The pattern

The examiner loves the **end of empire**: the **Commonwealth** and how it differs from the Empire (2015, 2017 — almost identical — and a 2024 short note), the **motives for decolonisation** with **India** (2019), how the **war and Cold War triggered** it (2024), and **global pressures v British decisions** with **case studies** (2026). The **Middle East** (Palestine and Suez, 2020; Suez short note 2022). **Churchill** in three roles (2022; short note 2018). The **Second World War** (2023; short note 2016). **Attlee** (2019). **Britain and the USA** to 9/11 (2018). Not yet set as full questions: the **war conferences and the UN**, **NATO** and the **Cold War** on their own, **home policy 1951–79**, and **Britain and the EEC**.

Part Six — The One-Liner Bank

HOW TO USE THIS · How to use the one-liners

Cover the answer after the arrow and say it aloud. **120 questions**; bold words are the ones examiners test. The past MCQs are solved in T8QA.

One-liners · The Second World War

1. When did Britain declare war on Germany? → **3 September 1939**.
2. What was the quiet period of 1939–40 called? → The "**Phoney War**".
3. When did Churchill become Prime Minister? → **10 May 1940**.
4. Who told Chamberlain "In the name of God, go!"? → **Leo Amery** (Norway debate).
5. What was the codename for the **Dunkirk** evacuation? → **Operation Dynamo**.
6. About how many troops were rescued from Dunkirk? → About **338,000**.
7. When did France surrender? → **June 1940**.
8. When was the **Battle of Britain**? → **July–October 1940**.
9. What was Hitler's planned invasion of Britain called? → **Operation Sea Lion**.
10. Which two fighter aircraft won the Battle of Britain? → The **Spitfire** and the **Hurricane**.
11. What was the German bombing of British cities called? → **The Blitz**.
12. About how many civilians died in the Blitz? → About **43,000**.
13. Where were the Enigma codes broken? → **Bletchley Park**.
14. Which **1941** US law supplied Britain with arms? → **Lend-Lease**.
15. What was Germany's invasion of the USSR called? → **Operation Barbarossa** (22 June 1941).
16. When did Japan attack **Pearl Harbor**? → **7 December 1941**.
17. When did Singapore fall? → **15 February 1942**.
18. Which battle of **1942** did Montgomery win in Egypt? → **El Alamein**.
19. What was the codename for the D-Day invasion? → **Operation Overlord** (6 June 1944).
20. When was **VE Day**? → **8 May 1945**.
21. On which two cities were atomic bombs dropped? → **Hiroshima** and **Nagasaki** (August 1945).
22. Which general led the "Forgotten Army" in Burma? → **General Slim**.
23. When were women first conscripted in Britain? → **December 1941**.
24. Which Labour minister directed wartime labour? → **Ernest Bevin**.

- 25.** About how many Britons died in the war? → About **450,000** (384,000 servicemen, 67,000 civilians).

One-liners · Churchill

- 26.** Where was Churchill born (1874)? → **Blenheim Palace**.
- 27.** In which famous cavalry charge did he ride (1898)? → **Omdurman**.
- 28.** From which war did he escape as a prisoner (1899)? → The **Boer War**.
- 29.** When did he cross from the Conservatives to the Liberals? → **1904**.
- 30.** Which campaign of **1915** cost him the Admiralty? → **Gallipoli** (Dardanelles).
- 31.** What mistake did he make as Chancellor (1925)? → Returning to the **gold standard**.
- 32.** What were his years out of office in the 1930s called? → The "**wilderness years**".
- 33.** Complete: "I have nothing to offer but..." → "...**blood, toil, tears and sweat**."
- 34.** Of whom did he say "so much owed by so many to so few"? → The **RAF pilots** (1940).
- 35.** Where did he give the **Iron Curtain** speech? → **Fulton, Missouri, 5 March 1946**.
- 36.** What did he call for at **Zurich** (1946)? → "A kind of **United States of Europe**".
- 37.** When was Churchill PM for the second time? → **1951–55**.
- 38.** Which prize did he win in **1953**? → The **Nobel Prize for Literature**.
- 39.** What was his six-volume history of the war? → ***The Second World War***.
- 40.** What was his history of the First World War? → ***The World Crisis***.
- 41.** Which biography did he write of his ancestor? → ***Marlborough: His Life and Times***.
- 42.** What did he write about the Sudan campaign? → ***The River War*** (1899).
- 43.** When did Churchill die? → **24 January 1965**.

One-liners · The conferences and the UN

- 44.** Which charter did Churchill and Roosevelt issue in **August 1941**? → The **Atlantic Charter**.
- 45.** Which point of the Charter mattered for the colonies? → **Self-determination** — peoples choosing their own government.
- 46.** Which conference (1943) demanded **unconditional surrender**? → **Casablanca**.
- 47.** Where did the **Big Three** first meet (1943)? → **Tehran**.
- 48.** What was Churchill and Stalin's secret deal on the Balkans (1944)? → The "**percentages agreement**".
- 49.** Which conference (**Feb 1945**) planned the division of Germany? → **Yalta**.
- 50.** Who replaced Churchill at **Potsdam**? → **Clement Attlee**.
- 51.** When was the UN Charter signed? → **26 June 1945** (San Francisco).
- 52.** When did the UN come into existence? → **24 October 1945**.

53. How many permanent members has the Security Council? → **Five**, each with a **veto**.

One-liners · Attlee

- 54.** How many seats did Labour win in **1945**? → **393**.
- 55.** Which report (1942) planned the welfare state? → The **Beveridge Report**.
- 56.** Name Beveridge's **Five Giants**. → **Want, Disease, Ignorance, Squalor, Idleness**.
- 57.** When did the **NHS** begin? → **5 July 1948**.
- 58.** Who created the NHS? → **Aneurin Bevan**.
- 59.** Which **1946** Act insured everyone? → The **National Insurance Act**.
- 60.** Which **1948** Act ended the Poor Law? → The **National Assistance Act**.
- 61.** When was the **Bank of England** nationalised? → **1946**.
- 62.** When was coal nationalised? → **1947** (1 January).
- 63.** How much did the US lend Britain in **1945**? → **\$3.75 billion**.
- 64.** Who warned of a "**financial Dunkirk**"? → **Keynes**.
- 65.** Which Chancellor was linked with "**austerity**"? → **Sir Stafford Cripps**.
- 66.** To what rate was the pound devalued in **1949**? → From \$4.03 to **\$2.80**.
- 67.** What was rationed after the war that was never rationed during it? → **Bread** (1946–48).
- 68.** Which **1946** Act created Stevenage and Harlow? → The **New Towns Act**.
- 69.** Who resigned in **1951** over health charges? → **Aneurin Bevan** (and Harold Wilson).
- 70.** Who wrote *The Audit of War*, criticising Labour's priorities? → **Correlli Barnett**.

One-liners · The Cold War and the USA

- 71.** What was the US promise (1947) to help free peoples resist communism? → The **Truman Doctrine**.
- 72.** When was **NATO** founded? → **4 April 1949**.
- 73.** What does NATO's **Article 5** say? → An attack on one is an **attack on all**.
- 74.** When did Britain test its first **atomic bomb**? → **1952**.
- 75.** Which agreement (1962) gave Britain **Polaris** missiles? → The **Nassau Agreement**.
- 76.** What was the 1948–60 conflict against communist guerrillas in Malaya? → The **Malayan Emergency**.
- 77.** Which PM refused to send troops to **Vietnam**? → **Harold Wilson**.
- 78.** When did Wilson announce withdrawal from **East of Suez**? → **January 1968**.
- 79.** Who coined the phrase "**special relationship**"? → **Churchill** (1946).
- 80.** Which report (2016) investigated the **Iraq War**? → The **Chilcot Report**.
- 81.** What did Blair write to Bush in July 2002? → "**I will be with you, whatever.**"

82. When did the Commons vote against military action in **Syria**? → **August 2013**.

One-liners · The Commonwealth

- 83.** Which report (**1839**) recommended responsible government in Canada? → The **Durham Report**.
- 84.** Who first called the Empire "a commonwealth of nations" (1884)? → **Lord Rosebery**.
- 85.** Which declaration (**1926**) made the Dominions equal? → The **Balfour Declaration**.
- 86.** Which statute (**1931**) gave the Dominions full sovereignty? → The **Statute of Westminster**.
- 87.** Which declaration (**1949**) allowed republics to join? → The **London Declaration**.
- 88.** Which country's wish to be a republic caused it? → **India**.
- 89.** What title did the King take in 1949? → **Head of the Commonwealth**.
- 90.** When was the **Commonwealth Secretariat** set up? → **1965**.
- 91.** Which country left in **1961** over apartheid? → **South Africa** (rejoined 1994).
- 92.** How many members does the Commonwealth have? → **56**.
- 93.** Name a member that was never a British colony. → **Mozambique** (or **Rwanda**, Gabon, Togo).
- 94.** Which declaration (**1991**) set democratic values? → The **Harare Declaration**.
- 95.** Who is Head of the Commonwealth now? → **King Charles III**.
- 96.** When was Elizabeth II crowned? → **2 June 1953**.

One-liners · Decolonisation, India and Suez

- 97.** What is the process by which colonies gained independence called? → **Decolonisation**.
- 98.** When did the **Muslim League** pass the Lahore Resolution? → **23 March 1940**.
- 99.** When did Congress launch **Quit India**? → **August 1942**.
- 100.** What was the **Cabinet Mission** (1946)? → A British plan for a united **federal** India.
- 101.** What was **Direct Action Day**? → **16 August 1946** — the Great Calcutta Killings.
- 102.** When did Attlee set a date for leaving India? → **20 February 1947** (by June 1948).
- 103.** Who was the last Viceroy? → **Lord Mountbatten**.
- 104.** What was the plan of **3 June 1947**? → **Partition** into India and Pakistan.
- 105.** When did Pakistan and India become independent? → **14 and 15 August 1947**.
- 106.** Who drew the partition borders? → **Sir Cyril Radcliffe**.
- 107.** When did **Ghana** become independent? → **6 March 1957**.
- 108.** Who gave the "**wind of change**" speech? → **Harold Macmillan** (Cape Town, **3 February 1960**).
- 109.** What was the 1952–60 Kikuyu rising in Kenya? → **Mau Mau**.

- 110.** Who declared **UDI** in Rhodesia (1965)? → **Ian Smith**.
- 111.** When did Hong Kong return to China? → **1 July 1997**.
- 112.** In which African country was **apartheid** imposed? → **South Africa** (from 1948).
- 113.** What did the **Balfour Declaration** of 1917 promise? → A **Jewish national home** in Palestine.
- 114.** Which hotel was bombed in Jerusalem in **1946**? → The **King David Hotel**.
- 115.** When did the British mandate in Palestine end? → **14–15 May 1948**.
- 116.** When did Nasser nationalise the Suez Canal? → **26 July 1956**.
- 117.** What was the secret Anglo-French-Israeli agreement called? → The **Protocol of Sèvres**.
- 118.** What did the Suez Crisis result in? → **British withdrawal** (and Eden's resignation).
- 119.** Which PM said Britons had "**never had it so good**"? → **Harold Macmillan** (1957).
- 120.** Who was PM during the **Winter of Discontent**? → **James Callaghan** (1978–79).

Part Seven — Revision Sheet · Topic 8: The Second World War, Attlee, the Cold War and the End of Empire

HOW TO USE THIS · How to use this sheet

Complete on its own for the night before the paper. Syllabus **Heads XII–XIII**. The largest topic: Commonwealth (2015, 2017, 2024 sn), decolonisation and India (2019, 2024, 2026), Suez and the Middle East (2020, 2022 sn), Churchill (2018 sn, 2022), WWII (2016 sn, 2023), Attlee (2019), Britain and the USA (2018).

R8.1 The Second World War

Causes: Versailles; Depression; Hitler's aims (Lebensraum); League's failure; appeasement; **Nazi–Soviet Pact 23 Aug 1939**; Poland invaded → war **3 Sept 1939**. **1939–41:** Phoney War; Norway; **Churchill PM 10 May 1940**; **Dunkirk** (Operation **Dynamo**, ~338,000); France falls; **Battle of Britain** (Jul–Oct 1940); **the Blitz** (~43,000 dead); Atlantic; Lend-Lease 1941. **1941–42:** Barbarossa; Atlantic Charter; Pearl Harbor; **Singapore** falls (15 Feb 1942). **1942–45:** **El Alamein**; Stalingrad; Italy; bombing; **D-Day 6 June 1944** (Overlord); Burma (Slim); **VE Day 8 May 1945**; Hiroshima, Nagasaki; VJ Aug 1945. **Home:** evacuation, rationing, women conscripted 1941, **Beveridge 1942**, Butler Act 1944. **Cost:** ~450,000 British dead; 70–85 million worldwide. **Aftermath:** UN; superpowers; Cold War; decolonisation; Britain exhausted.

R8.2 Churchill

Warrior: Cuba, India, **Omdurman 1898**, Boer War escape 1899; Admiralty 1911–15 (**Gallipoli**); Western Front 1916; war leader 1940–45 (defiance May 1940; speeches; Mediterranean strategy; Roosevelt, Stalin). **Statesman:** Liberal reformer 1908–11; Irish Treaty 1921; Chancellor 1924–29 (gold standard); warned against Hitler; conferences (Atlantic Charter, Casablanca, Tehran, Moscow percentages, Yalta, Potsdam); **Iron Curtain, Fulton 5 Mar 1946**; Zurich 1946; PM 1951–55. **Man of letters:** *River War*, *My Early Life*, *World Crisis*, *Marlborough*, *The Second World War* (6 vols), *History of the English-Speaking Peoples*; **Nobel Prize 1953**. **Critics:** Gallipoli, gold standard, India, Singapore, Bengal famine, Dresden.

R8.3 Conferences and the UN

Atlantic Charter 14 Aug 1941 (self-determination); Arcadia (Germany first; Declaration by United Nations 1 Jan 1942); **Casablanca 1943** (unconditional surrender); **Tehran 1943**; Bretton Woods, Dumbarton Oaks 1944; Moscow percentages 1944; **Yalta Feb 1945** (zones, veto, Poland); **San Francisco — Charter 26 June 1945**; UN born **24 Oct 1945**; **Potsdam**

(Attlee replaces Churchill). **UN**: General Assembly; **Security Council (5 permanent, veto: USA, USSR, UK, France, China)**; Secretariat; ICJ; ECOSOC; agencies.

R8.4 Attlee 1945–51

Problems: debt (~£21bn), sold assets, exports down, **dollar gap**; Lend-Lease ended; "financial Dunkirk"; bomb damage; **Five Giants**. **Social**: Family Allowances 1946; **National Insurance 1946**; **NHS 5 July 1948** (Bevan); **National Assistance 1948**; Butler Act; school age 15; ~**1m homes** (prefabs), New Towns 1946. **Economic**: **US loan \$3.75bn**; **Marshall Aid ~\$2.7bn**; export drive; Cripps austerity; bread rationing 1946–48; **nationalisation** — Bank of England **1946**, coal 1947, rail and electricity 1948, gas 1949, steel 1951. **Crises**: fuel 1947; convertibility 1947; **devaluation 1949 (\$4.03 → \$2.80)**; Korea; Bevan resigns 1951. **Judgement**: social triumph (Hennessy, Morgan); economic record mixed (Barnett).

R8.5 The Cold War and the USA

Iron Curtain 1946; Britain hands Greece to US → **Truman Doctrine 1947**; Marshall Plan; Dunkirk Treaty 1947; Brussels 1948; **Berlin airlift 1948–49**; **NATO 4 April 1949** (Bevin; Art. 5); A-bomb 1952, H-bomb 1957; **Korea 1950–53**; **Malaya 1948–60**; **Nassau 1962 (Polaris)**; Wilson — no troops for Vietnam; **East of Suez Jan 1968**. **Subservient?** For: Suez, nuclear dependence, bases, Libya 1986, Gulf 1991, Afghanistan, **Iraq 2003** ("I will be with you, whatever"; Chilcot 2016). Against: Suez itself, Vietnam, Heath 1973, Grenada 1983, Syria vote 2013, AIIB 2015, Iran deal 2018, Palestine recognised 2025. **Verdict**: dependent partner by choice, not servant.

R8.6 The Commonwealth

Stages: Durham Report 1839 → Dominions (Canada 1867, Australia 1901, NZ 1907, SA 1910); Rosebery 1884 "commonwealth of nations"; Smuts 1917; Irish Treaty 1921; **Balfour Declaration 1926** ("autonomous communities ... equal in status"); **Statute of Westminster 1931**; **London Declaration April 1949** (India republic; **Head of the Commonwealth**; "British" dropped) = creation of the modern Commonwealth; Ireland leaves 1949; **Secretariat 1965**; SA leaves 1961 (back 1994); Singapore 1971, **Harare 1991**, Charter 2013; Mozambique 1995, Rwanda 2009, Gabon, Togo 2022; **56 members**; Charles III Head 2022. **Differences from Empire**: power v consent; subordination v equality; London rules v self-government; Crown sovereign v symbolic Head (republics); force v free to leave; British interests v shared values; British possessions v includes non-colonies; hierarchy v multiracial.

R8.7 Decolonisation and India

Motives: economic weakness and cost; nationalism; WWII (Singapore, Atlantic Charter); **USA, USSR, UN (Res. 1514, 1960)**; Cold War (hand to moderates); Labour ideology; **Macmillan's audit 1957 and "wind of change" 3 Feb 1960**; **Macleod**; Suez; Europe; Hola 1959. **India** — **why**: Congress, Gandhi, **Quit India 1942**; League, Jinnah, **Lahore**

1940; war weakness; **INA trials, RIN mutiny 1946**; Labour; cost. **How**: Cripps 1942; Simla 1945; elections 1945–46; **Cabinet Mission 1946**; **Direct Action 16 Aug 1946**; **Attlee's statement 20 Feb 1947**; **Mountbatten; 3 June Plan**; **Independence Act July 1947**; **14–15 Aug 1947**; Radcliffe Line; ~12–15m displaced, hundreds of thousands killed; Kashmir. **Other cases**: Malaya 1957, **Ghana 1957, Kenya 1963** (Mau Mau), Nigeria 1960, Aden 1967, **Rhodesia UDI 1965 → Zimbabwe 1980, Hong Kong 1997**. **WWII and Cold War as triggers**; global pressures set direction, British decisions set pace.

R8.8 Palestine and Suez

Palestine: McMahon–Hussein; **Balfour 1917**; mandate; Arab revolt 1936–39; Peel 1937; **White Paper 1939**; Irgun, Lehi; **King David Hotel 22 July 1946**; Truman's 100,000; Exodus 1947; cost ~100,000 troops; to UN Feb 1947; **Res. 181 (29 Nov 1947)**; left **14–15 May 1948**; Israel; Nakba. **Suez**: 1954 agreement to leave Canal Zone (out June 1956); Nasser; Czech arms; Aswan loans withdrawn 19 July; **nationalised 26 July 1956**; **Sèvres**; Israel attacks 29 Oct; ultimatum 30 Oct; bombing 31 Oct; **Port Said landings 5–6 Nov**; US pressure — run on sterling; ceasefire 6 Nov; UNEF (Pearson); out by 22 Dec; **Eden resigns 9 Jan 1957**. **Why withdraw**: US (decisive), sterling, UN, USSR, Commonwealth, home opposition. **Results**: end of independent great-power role; special relationship rebuilt; faster decolonisation; Nasser triumphant; Eisenhower Doctrine.

R8.9 Home and Europe 1951–79

Churchill (rationing ends 1954; **coronation 2 June 1953**); Eden; **Macmillan ("never had it so good", 1957)**; Butskellism; Wilson (devaluation 1967; **Swinging London**; social reforms); Heath (**EEC 1 Jan 1973**; decimal 1971; three-day week 1974); **referendum 1975 (67%)**; **IMF 1976**; **Winter of Discontent 1978–79 (Callaghan)**; no-confidence 311–310 (28 Mar 1979). **EEC**: out of Rome 1957; EFTA 1960; applications 1961 (**de Gaulle veto 14 Jan 1963**) and 1967 (veto); joined 1973.

VERDICT · The whole topic in one sentence

Britain won the Second World War under Churchill and built the welfare state under Attlee, but — exhausted, indebted and pressed by two anti-colonial superpowers and rising nationalism — it gave up its empire for a free Commonwealth, learned at Suez that it could not act without the USA, and at last found a new role in Europe.